

An aerial photograph showing a large herd of bison crossing a winding river. The bison are spread across the river and the surrounding grassy banks, which are a mix of green and golden-brown. The river is dark and flows from the top left towards the bottom right.

BIG LIFE^{SKY}

SEVENTH ISSUE 2026

BIG SKY RESORT'S FUTURE, REALIZED

The transformation from
village to summit is here.

MISADVENTURES IN YELLOWSTONE NATIONAL PARK

Tragedy, mystery, and missteps.

EATING LOCAL

Exploring Big Sky's
culinary landscape.



HOTEL FREE WEST



A CRAFTED, SPIRITED, INSPIRED
BOUTIQUE HOTEL EXPERIENCE.

81 ROOMS, RESTAURANT, CAFÉ, BAR & LOUNGE, SHOPS,
FITNESS ROOM, HOT TUB, COLD PLUNGE, SAUNAS,
OUTDOOR DECK, AND MORE.

ARRIVING 2027.



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This year marks the seventh edition of *Big Sky Life*, a magazine by Lone Mountain Land Company that celebrates the spirit, stories, and people that make this mountain town unlike any other. While Big Sky is best known for its legendary slopes, its heart beats far beyond the lift lines. *Big Sky Life* explores the depth of this community, from the visionaries shaping its future to the wild places and wildlife that define its character.

In this issue, you'll explore the next chapter of Big Sky Resort and the bold vision shaping its future while savoring local favorites that define Big Sky's dining scene. You'll journey beyond Big Sky to one of Montana's most inspiring art destinations, uncover the great mysteries of Yellowstone National Park, meet the wildlife that share this wild place, see how locals spend their days, and much more.

Big Sky Life was created to be more than a magazine. It's a reflection of the community itself. We hope you feel inspired with every turn of the page.

***Big Sky Life* is produced by Lone Mountain Land Company.**

www.lonemountainland.com | www.bigsky.com

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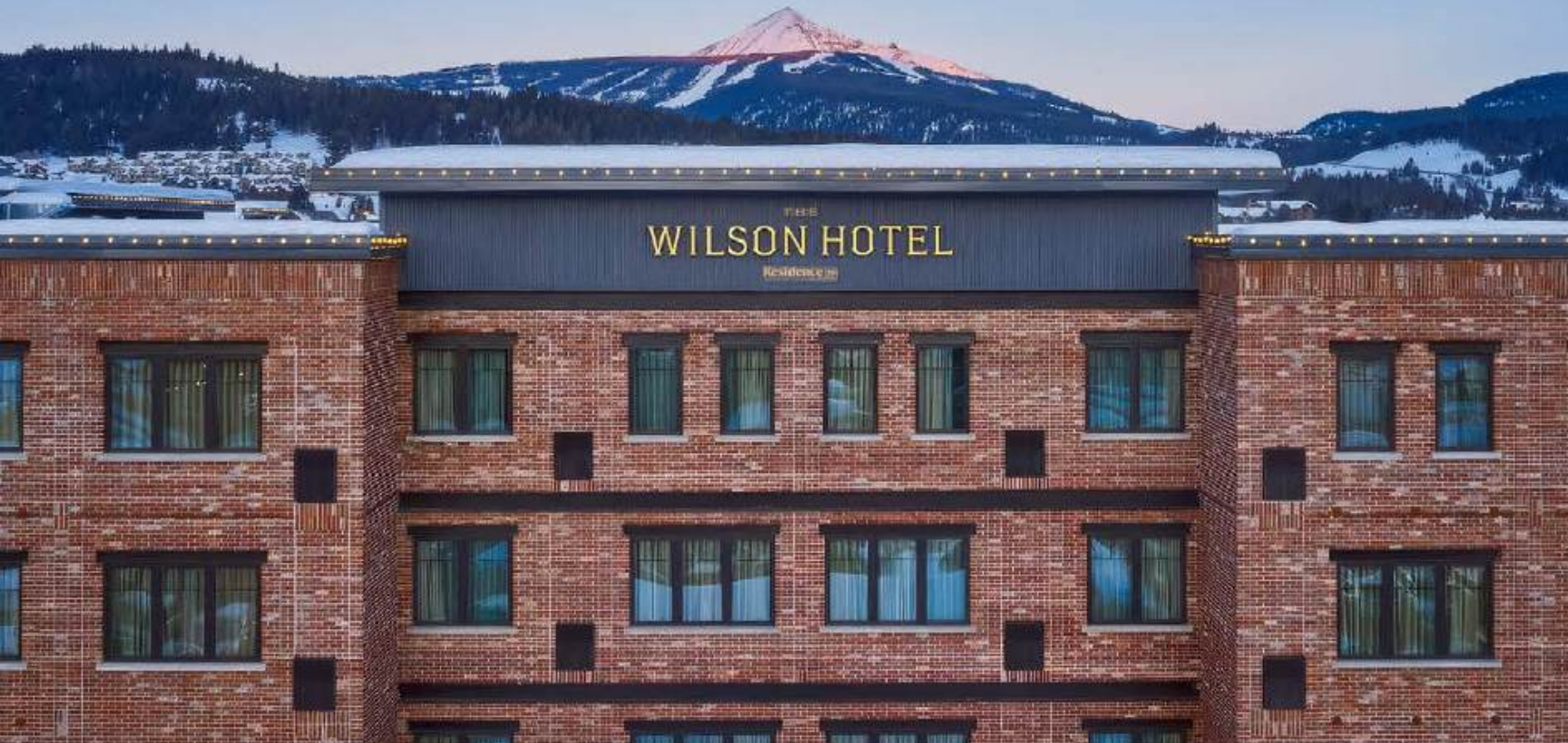
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Cover photo by **Joe Esenther**



Your Home Base in 2026

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THE INN RESIDENCES

Ownership at The Inn is offered in deeded, one-quarter ownership interests, giving you 90 days of turnkey, fully-managed ownership in Big Sky. These 32 fully-furnished three- and four-bedroom Residences with connected lock-off suite provide a unique second home ownership opportunity in a luxury Residence steps from Montage Big Sky. Connected by an underground pathway, Owners will enjoy access to the resort's many amenities including five dining establishments, Signature Spa Montage, a bowling alley, golf and sports simulator room, and indoor and outdoor pools, plus ski-in, ski-out access to Big Sky Resort.

Owners will also enjoy the benefits of membership at Spanish Peaks Mountain Club, which includes private concierge services, an 18-hole Tom Weiskopf Championship Golf Course, a new 10-hole Par 3 course, clubhouse, upcoming Aspire Lodge, and a year-round calendar of special, member-only events and experiences.

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MONTANA FLY FISHING PHOTOGRAPHY.

THREE SHOOTERS TAKE US BEHIND THE LENS.



Stoneflies are on the trout's menu.

The strike.
Fish on.

Photography by Joe Klementovich

Fly fishing is one of Joe's great passions, and his photography shows it. "From figuring out what the trout are eating, picking the right fly, making a great cast, the strike, playing the fish, admiring the vibrant colors, and carefully releasing back into the water. This is what Montana is all about."





The colors
of a trout.

Time for a perfect cast.



A short look at a nice trout.

Looking down on the
Yellowstone River





Paradise Valley in fall.



Photography by Jonathan Finch

Jonathan shoots a wide array of mountain sports and landscapes ranging from skiing to mountain biking, and of course, fly fishing. "Montana is just a great place to shoot fly fishing," says Johnathan. "The rivers are just beautiful, and I try to capture various moments, be it casting, mountain backdrops, picking out the right fly, hooking up with a good trout."

Flies in which
you can have faith.



The Madison River on a cold morning.





The visor: a retirement home for flies.



Fish stories abound in the bar.



Homeward from a memorable day.



The side channel awaits.

Photography by Andy Anderson

Andy has spent many, many years behind the lens, but one of his favorite subjects to shoot is fly fishing in Montana. In his own words, "Montana is just home to so many beautiful things: amazing rivers and streams, big trout, mountain views, and fishing with friends. It is one of the great sports to shoot, and the images are always truly memorable ones."



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MEET YOUR WILD NEIGHBORS

The Bighorn Sheep

Story by Robert Earle Howells



A bighorn lamb from the Spanish Peaks herd, born high on craggy cliffs where ewes seek safety from predators. Later in the year, they wander into meadows like this—a sight biologists call “ridiculously cute.” Photograph by Nathan Peterson

IT'S NOT REALLY for our amusement that Big Sky's bighorn sheep muster and graze roadside in winter. Nor are cliques of ewes nestling their young up beneath mountain crags in late spring staging some sort of cuteness contest. And the fall rut—when rams take center stage in head-butting contests that seem unsurvivable—is not actually a spectator sport. But taken together, you arguably have Big Sky's most compelling year-round wildlife spectacle: wild, dramatic and relatively easy to spot.

Big Sky's local sheep, known as the Spanish Peaks herd, are a common sight in winter along Highway 191 between mile markers

“People can help keep our sheep healthy and safe if they recreate responsibly and try not to approach or disturb bighorn sheep, especially during their winter survival period or spring lambing.”

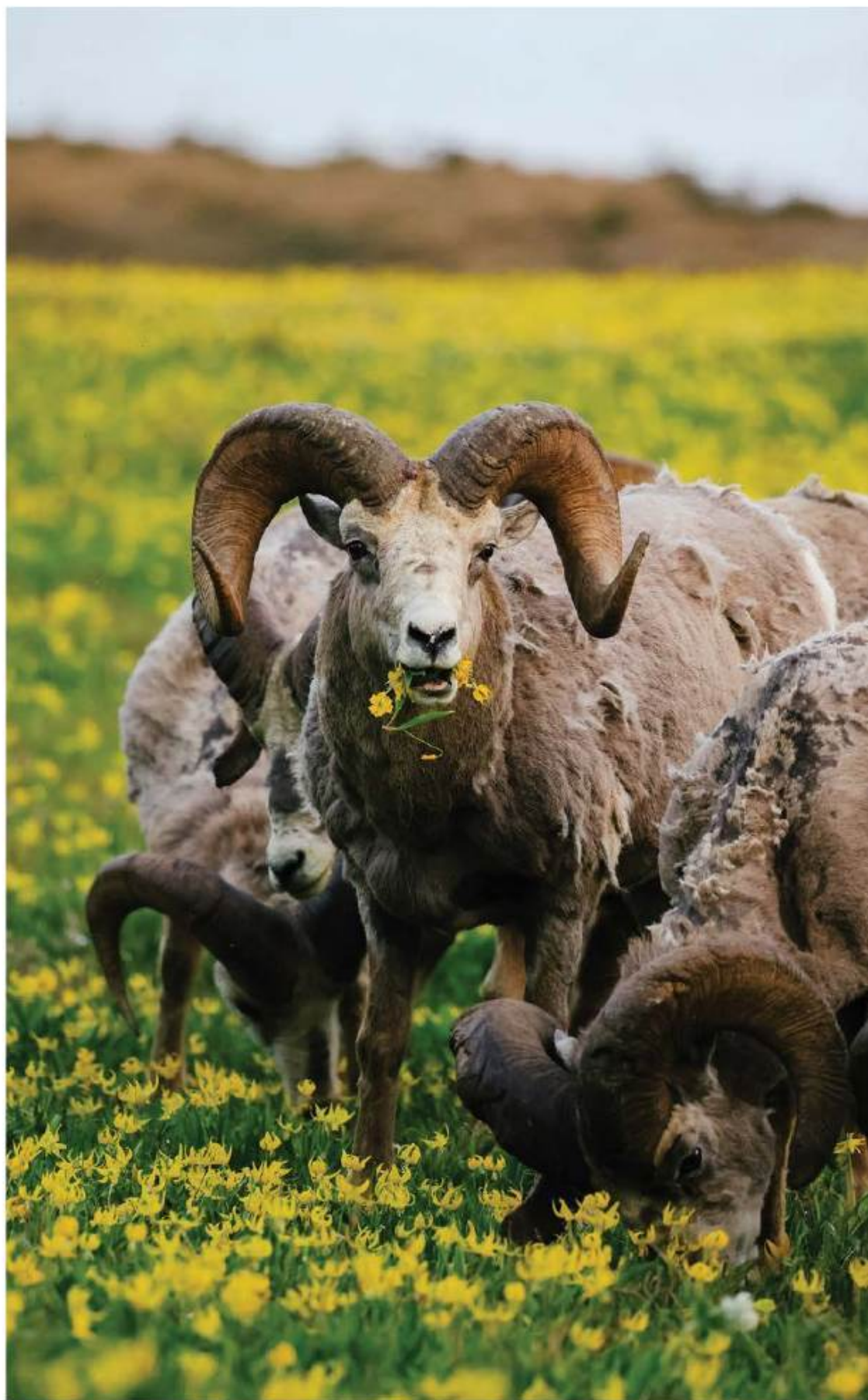
- Julie Cunningham, Wildlife Biologist
with Montana Fish, Wildlife & Parks

55 and 48, just after you turn west on Lone Mountain Trail and are headed toward Town Center. What are they doing? Eating, of course, and they are not to be approached, fed (even if they look a tad thin), or chased by your dog. It's survival season for these charismatic ungulates. The herd, about 100 to 150 strong, is relatively healthy and fairly tolerant of human presence. And they represent something of a success story. Disease and habitat intrusion drastically reduced bighorn numbers until wildlife management agencies in Montana and elsewhere launched recovery efforts in the 20th century. While sheep were reintroduced in some parts of the state, the Spanish Peaks sheep are native to the area. Montana now has 45 populations of bighorns totaling about 5,700 sheep, but wildlife biologist Julie Cunningham with Montana Fish, Wildlife & Parks reminds us to be cautious: “People can help keep our sheep healthy and safe if they recreate responsibly,” she says, “and try not to approach or disturb bighorn sheep, especially during their winter survival period or spring lambing.”

At first glance, the life of a bighorn sheep may seem tough. They face brutal Rocky Mountain winters, predation from mountain lions, and (for the males) a lifetime of lugging around a 40-pound set of horns. But the animals are extraordinarily well adapted for the task. Those horns serve a mating function: useful for attracting potential mates and for demonstrating dominance during head-butting displays. During the November rut, rival 250-pound rams charge one another at 20 miles per hour, and the sound of bashing foreheads can be heard a mile away. Those horns, incidentally, also indicate the age of the rams. Growth stops during the lean winter season to help them conserve energy, leaving a ring that corresponds to the number of winters survived.

Bighorns are susceptible to predation from mountain lions, and a bit less so from bears and wolves. Here, their camouflage coat and nimbleness in steep terrain come in handy, especially in May and June when groups of ewes retreat to high craggy cliffs to birth their lambs. (Sheep don't quite match goats for dexterity, though. As FWP's chief pilot, Joe Rahn, says, "Sheep go where men don't go; goats go where sheep don't go.") Being merely human, you might not see newly born lambs with their moms, but you can spot them later in the year grazing in mountain meadows, and the sight is adorable. The scientific term, says Cunningham, is "ridiculously cute."

The success of bighorn conservation has allowed wildlife managers to establish a tightly controlled hunting program whose license fees pay right back into bighorn conservation research. Only three licenses are issued for the fall season in the Spanish Peaks area. FWP also auctions a bighorn license to conservation organizations that has fetched as much as \$480,000, making the free-of-charge sight of sheep munching behind the Conoco station seem even more special.



A bighorn ram from Big Sky's native herd grazing on wildflowers. Those heavy curls, grown over years and marked by winter growth rings, are both a survival tool and a sign of age and strength. Photograph by Nathan Peterson

"We built this to be a model for other headwater communities, and to show what's possible when conservation and recreation work together."

Rich Chandler,
vice president of
environmental
operations for
Lone Mountain
Land Company



Snowmaking underway at Big Sky Resort. For the first time this year, the resort is producing snow with reclaimed water as part of its long-term sustainability goals, which makes it the first public ski resort in Montana to do so. *Photograph courtesy of Big Sky Resort, Patrick Conroy*

BIG SKY RESORT BECOMES MONTANA'S FIRST PUBLIC SKI AREA TO USE RECLAIMED WATER FOR SNOWMAKING. Yellowstone Club enters its third year using the same sustainable approach.

THE MONTANA DEPARTMENT OF ENVIRONMENTAL QUALITY HAS APPROVED a plan by Spanish Peaks Mountain Club, part of Big Sky Resort's ski terrain, to convert highly-treated reclaimed water into snow for base layer snowpack. This makes Big Sky the first public ski area in Montana to do so. The move follows the success of a similar program at Yellowstone Club, which enters its third year of reclaimed water snowmaking on Eglise Mountain during the 2025/26 ski season.

Rich Chandler, vice president of environmental operations for Lone Mountain Land Company, says the YC program has become second nature. "At this point, it's just the norm," he said. "The Mountain Operations team is fully dialed in, and it feels good to be in year three doing great conservation work."

The Spanish Peaks program, developed in partnership with Big Sky Resort and the Big Sky County Water and Sewer District, uses highly treated and disinfected water that would otherwise be stored and used for irrigation. The water meets

the highest reuse classification the state authorizes. Phase one at Spanish Peaks will use up to 23 million gallons of reclaimed water on Spirit Mountain and Southern Comfort terrain, expanding to 44 million gallons once the second phase is built.

Chandler credited the local water and sewer district for superlative water quality and emphasized that the recycled snow is safe. "This water goes through a robust review process and meets all Montana Department of Environmental Quality standards for human health and safety. Furthermore, it is sampled weekly during active snowmaking operations as an additional layer of quality control," he said. "It's cleaner than most freshwater sources typically used for snowmaking."

Yellowstone Club's success has drawn interest from other Montana ski areas, and Chandler hopes Big Sky's adoption of the technology will inspire more to follow. "We don't want to hold this close to our chest," he said. "We built this to be a model for other headwater communities, and to show what's possible when conservation and recreation work together."

HOTEL FREE WEST BREAKS GROUND IN BIG SKY'S TOWN CENTER

HOTEL FREE WEST ISN'T JUST FOR TRAVELERS PASSING THROUGH—it's for Big Sky itself. Lone Mountain Land Company (LMLC) has broken ground on the 81-room independent boutique hotel, which will add gathering spaces, wellness amenities, and new walkable connections to Town Center. Construction is already underway, with opening slated for summer 2027.

"Hotel Free West is the result of meticulous vision and planning," said Matt Kidd, President of LMLC. "It's not just a hotel for visitors—it's something that will add to the vibrancy of Town Center and serve the local community too."

Plans call for 81 guest rooms, a signature restaurant and lounge, a café for early risers, curated retail shops, and a spacious outdoor deck featuring a hot tub, cold plunge, and saunas. A new street, Plaza Avenue, will connect Town Center Avenue and Aspen Leaf Drive, creating smoother pedestrian access for locals and guests.

Hotel Free West blends modern mountain design with rustic character. Columbia Hospitality, the team behind luxury mountain resort destinations such as Sage Lodge in Paradise Valley, MT, and Salish Lodge in Snoqualmie, WA, will manage the property.

"This is about creating a gathering place that feels authentic to Big Sky," said Matt Hagerman, president of hotels & resorts at Columbia Hospitality. "We want it to be a place locals can enjoy while also welcoming visitors from outside the community."

"We want it to be a place locals can enjoy while also welcoming visitors from outside the community."

Matt Hagerman, president of hotels & resorts at Columbia Hospitality

When it opens, Hotel Free West will not only provide another option for staying in Town Center but will also



A preview of Hotel Free West, designed to anchor the next phase of growth in Town Center. Rendering courtesy of Lone Mountain Land Company

generate year-round energy for local businesses, adding to the momentum of Big Sky's growing downtown. The project underscores the community's evolution toward a more connected, walkable, and experience-driven destination.

BUCK'S IS BACK!

AFTER CLOSING ITS DOORS IN 2023, the beloved Buck's Roadhouse, formerly known as Buck's T-4, has officially reopened—restored, reimagined, and ready to welcome the Big Sky community once again.

For more than 75 years, Buck's was a cornerstone of the canyon, first opening as Buck's T-4 Lodge in the 1940s to serve travelers, hunters, and locals alike. Known for its hearty Montana hospitality and legendary prime rib, it became a gathering place for generations before closing in 2023.

Now operated by hospitality group Après Cru, Buck's joins sister restaurants Block 3 and Tips Up in a new chapter of Big Sky dining. Après Cru, known for its community-driven restaurants and partnerships with Coachella, Auberge Resorts, and jetBlue, brings a mix of fresh energy and thoughtful care to these local favorites.

"Après Cru shares our vision for authentic, high-quality hospitality that serves both locals and visitors. Their respect for the legacy of Buck's and the commitment to community-based operations make them an exciting partner for Big Sky," said Lone Mountain Land Company's executive vice president of hospitality operations, John Speers.

Stop in, raise a glass, and celebrate the return of a true Big Sky classic. Buck's is open, and the spirit of community is alive and well.



Buck's Roadhouse, formerly known as Buck's T-4, has reopened its doors, bringing back the warm hospitality and canyon tradition that has defined it for more than 75 years. Photograph courtesy of Lone Mountain Land Company

"Après Cru shares our vision for authentic, high-quality hospitality that serves both locals and visitors. Their respect for the legacy of Buck's and the commitment to community-based operations make them an exciting partner for Big Sky."

John Speers, executive vice president of hospitality operations at Lone Mountain Land Company

"Reliable, quality child care is absolutely critical to the health of our community. We are thrilled to open the doors of GRCC Big Sky to welcome families into a space that is safe, supportive, and built around the needs of young children."

Jackie Ng,
GRCC director



The newly opened GRCC Big Sky facility, designed to meet the community's growing need for high-quality early childhood care. *Photograph by Joe Esenther*

WELCOME TO THE FUTURE OF THE ARTS IN BIG SKY

THE ARTS COUNCIL OF BIG SKY HAS FOUND ITS NEW HOME at 77 Lone Peak Drive, the former Choppers restaurant, and plans are underway to transform the space into a creative hub for the Big Sky community and beyond. The new center will serve as a gathering place for classes, performances, exhibitions, and collaboration—a permanent home for the arts in Big Sky.

The council has launched a \$12 million campaign, with \$6 million needed by fall of 2026 to begin construction. "Our capital campaign is already in motion," said executive director Brian Hurlbut. "We've raised funds to cover architectural fees and early planning,

and now we're working with major donors and community partners to secure the cornerstone gifts that will really get us going."

The remodel will expand the existing 7,700-square-foot building into 10,000 square feet of creative space. Plans include five classrooms, a dedicated youth space, a basement "sound garden" for musicians, a home for Big Sky's future community radio station, 98.3 FM, and a rooftop patio designed to be "one of the premier event venue rental spaces in Big Sky when it's finished," said Hurlbut.

Construction is slated to begin in fall 2026, with completion targeted for

2028. In the meantime, the Arts Council has already moved its offices into the building. "We're here now, and we'd love for people to stop by and see the future of the arts in Big Sky," Hurlbut said.

For Hurlbut, the project is about more than bricks and mortar. "Yes, it's a space for the Arts Council," he said, "but more importantly it's a space for the community—a place where the arts are accessible to all, and where Big Sky can truly grow into a hub for arts and culture."

For more information, visit bigskyarts.org.



FAMILIES IN BIG SKY NOW HAVE EXPANDED access to high-quality early childhood education with the official opening of Gallatin River Child Care's (GRCC) new facility in Town Center. Located at 5 Spruce Cone, the center can serve up to 24 children from six weeks to three years old and is designed to meet a pressing community need for reliable infant and toddler care.

The new Big Sky location complements GRCC's existing Gallatin Gateway facility, which opened in February 2024 and recently expanded capacity. Together, the two centers are helping address the challenge of accessibility, affordability, and availability of child care for working families in southwest Montana. Support from Lone Mountain Land Company (LMLC) and the Yellowstone Club Community Foundation (YCCF) made the new facility possible.

"Reliable, quality child care is absolutely critical to the health of our community," said Jackie Ng, GRCC Director, who has more than 20 years of experience in early childhood education. "We are thrilled to open the doors of GRCC Big Sky and to welcome families into a space that is safe,

supportive, and built around the needs of young children. The demand for care here is significant, and we are humbled and grateful to be part of the solution."

GRCC is a 501(c)(3) nonprofit organization, and its mission is rooted in serving families first. As part of its services, GRCC Big Sky is offering expanded hours of operation to accommodate the varied schedules of local families and businesses. Limited business memberships are also available to help small businesses reserve slots for employees on a quarterly basis, providing flexibility for seasonal workforce shifts.

Community partners emphasize that this new facility is just the beginning. Alongside YCCF and Big Sky Resort Area District (BSRAD), Greater Gallatin United Way is leading the creation of the Big Sky Early Childhood Education Alliance, a long-term initiative to strengthen facilities and funding for all early childhood providers in the community.

Families interested in learning more about enrollment or business memberships can visit gallatinriverchildcare.com.

Plans include five classrooms, a dedicated youth space, a basement "sound garden" for musicians, a home for Big Sky's future community radio station, 98.3 FM, and a rooftop patio.



Architectural rendering of the new Arts Council of Big Sky space. Rendering courtesy of CCY Architects



Native gardens at Crail Ranch, showcasing some of the plants that thrive naturally in Big Sky's high-alpine environment. *Photograph courtesy of Big Sky SNO*

"Native plants are the foundation of food webs and essential for sustaining ecosystems."

Jennifer Mohler,
executive director
of Grow Wild

ROOTED IN PLACE: WHY NATIVE LANDSCAPING MATTERS IN BIG SKY

IN BIG SKY, the wild edges of the Greater Yellowstone Ecosystem press right up against the backyards and driveways of a fast-growing mountain town. Moose wander through neighborhoods, elk graze in meadows, and bears forage along trails just steps from homes. Here, the choices made in a single yard ripple outward into the surrounding landscape.

That's where native landscaping comes in. More than an aesthetic choice, planting native species is an act of stewardship. Native plants form the foundation of ecosystems, providing food and shelter for pollinators, songbirds, and larger mammals while cleaning the air, filtering water, and stabilizing soil. In a place where mountain weather, steep slopes, and short growing seasons can make landscaping feel challenging, native plants thrive naturally, needing less water, fertilizer, and maintenance over time. They are built for this environment and for the wildlife that depends on it.

"Native plants are the foundation of food webs and essential for sustaining ecosystems," says Jennifer Mohler,

Executive Director of Grow Wild, a Big Sky-based nonprofit dedicated to conserving native species in the Upper Gallatin Watershed. "Without these plants, wildlife has to work harder to survive."

Still, investing in native landscaping can feel daunting. That's why Alpenskapes was created—a collaborative partnership that helps Big Sky property owners make informed, ecologically sound landscaping choices.

"Alpenskapes exists to be the jumping-off point for anyone who wants to do better with their landscaping," explains Lizzie Peyton, Director of Big Sky SNO (Sustainability Network Organization).

Through Alpenskapes, landowners can find resources online and connect with experts who provide free property visits. The partnership brings together four key organizations: the Big Sky Fire Department (for defensible space and firewise landscaping), Grow Wild (for native and invasive plants), the Gallatin River Task Force (for water conservation), and SNO (for coordination and sustainability strategy).



A native bee gathering pollen from a native flower—one of countless small interactions that strengthen Big Sky's biodiversity. *Photograph by Micah Berman*

"Each partner brings their expertise," Peyton says. "When you invite us out, you are not just learning how to care for your yard. You are contributing to the health and resilience of the whole ecosystem watershed. Being a good land steward is also about being a good neighbor." Start your own native landscaping journey or request a site visit at alpenskapes.org.

COLD SMOKE: BIG SKY'S LARGEST HOUSING EFFORT MOVES FORWARD

BIG SKY'S HISTORIC COMMUNITY HOUSING project is moving ahead. Cold Smoke, led by the Big Sky Community Housing Trust (BSCHT), will bring nearly 400 homes for local workers, making it the largest workforce housing initiative in Big Sky's history.

The effort began with securing land, funded through Big Sky Resort Tax. In May, Big Sky voters approved a \$60 million bond package, the largest investment ever made through Resort Tax. That support ensures not only the land purchase but also the installation

of critical infrastructure such as roads, water, and utilities. The bond's passage reflected an overwhelming show of community support, with months of public meetings, town halls, and neighborhood conversations helping residents understand what the project would mean for the future of Big Sky. "Cold Smoke represents the kind of collaboration that defines Big Sky," said Matt Kidd, president of Lone Mountain Land Company. "When the public and private sectors work together toward a shared goal, we can solve challenges that once felt out of reach."

"The community has come together on a scale that is unprecedented to solve what is Big Sky's biggest challenge," said David O'Connor, executive director of BSCHT. "Housing affects everything else, from child care to health care to staffing our businesses. Cold Smoke is our chance to address that head on."

Plans call for 264 apartments and 125 single-family homes, all permanently reserved for Big Sky's year-round workforce. The homes will be sold under a community land trust model, which ensures long-term affordability by separating ownership of the land from the home itself. According to O'Connor, Cold Smoke may be the largest project of its kind in the country composed entirely of affordable homes. The development will also incorporate community feedback on design and sustainability, with outreach planned as infrastructure begins.

BSCHT expects to close on the land by the end of 2025. Infrastructure work is scheduled to begin in April 2026, with apartments breaking ground in 2027 and single-family homes in 2028.

"This project is about creating a future where people who work in Big Sky can also build their lives here," O'Connor said. "Cold Smoke is our opportunity to secure that future together."



Conceptual rendering of the Cold Smoke development. *Rendering courtesy of Big Sky Housing Trust*

"The community has come together on a scale that is unprecedented to solve what is Big Sky's biggest challenge." David O'Conner, executive director of BSCHT

FIRE READY BIG SKY

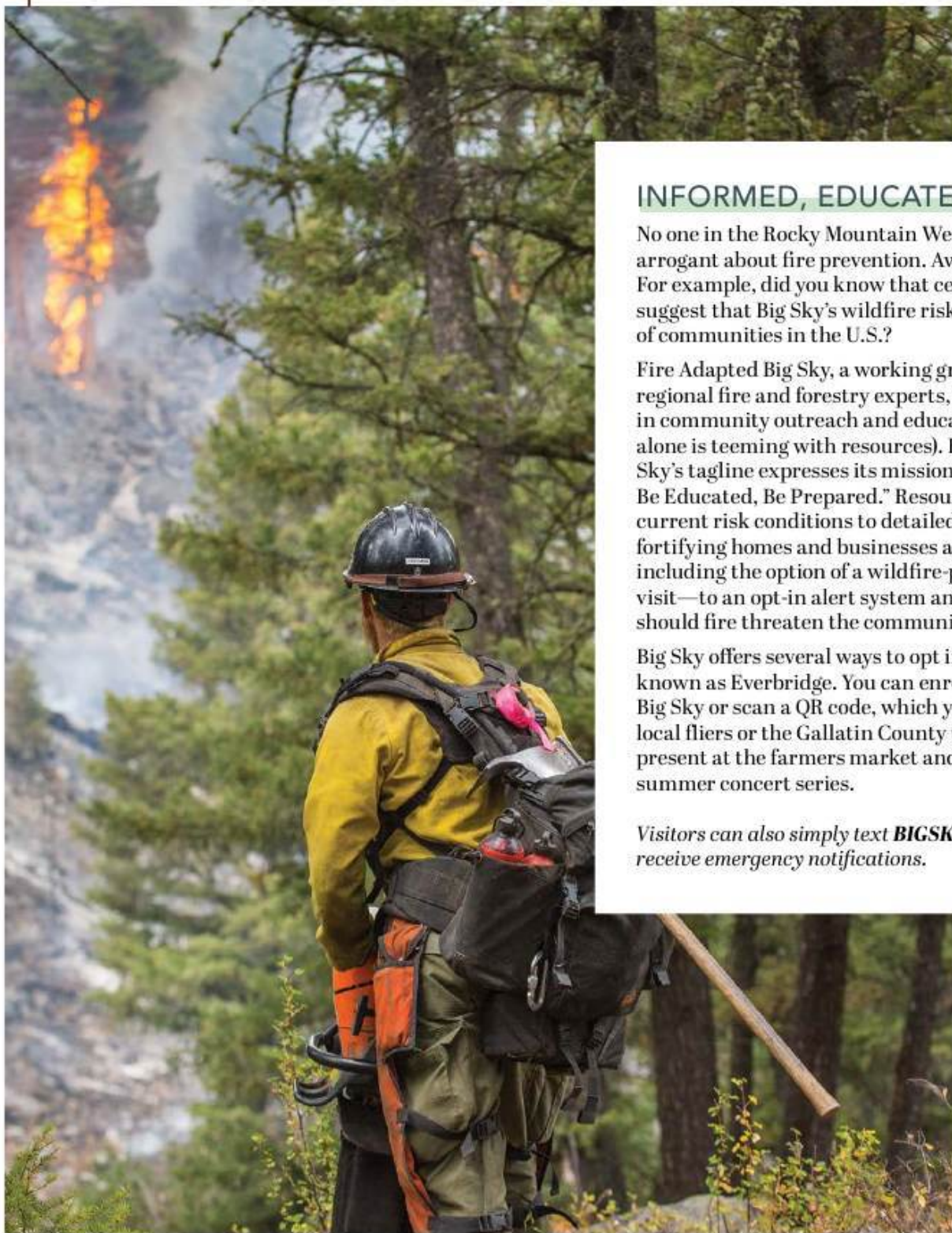
A look at modern wildfire preparedness.

Story by Robert Earle Howells

DO YOU REMEMBER when wildfire last tore through Big Sky's corner of the Rocky Mountains? Probably not—it hasn't happened since 1910, and nothing major has occurred since. Those charged with protecting Big Sky from such events would like to keep it that way and are employing an arsenal of modern methods and high-tech strategies to do just that. Safeguarding Big Sky doesn't just fall on the shoulders of professional firefighters. Fire protection in the area is a total community effort that boils down to three things: mitigation/education, fuel reduction/forest restoration, and monitoring/detecting.

View from Ramshorn Peak trail toward the Gallatin Range north of Big Sky.
Photograph courtesy of US National Park Service, Jacob W. Frank

→ DID YOU KNOW THAT CERTAIN RISK MODELS SUGGEST THAT BIG SKY'S WILDFIRE RISK IS HIGHER THAN 96% OF COMMUNITIES IN THE U.S.?



INFORMED, EDUCATED, PREPARED

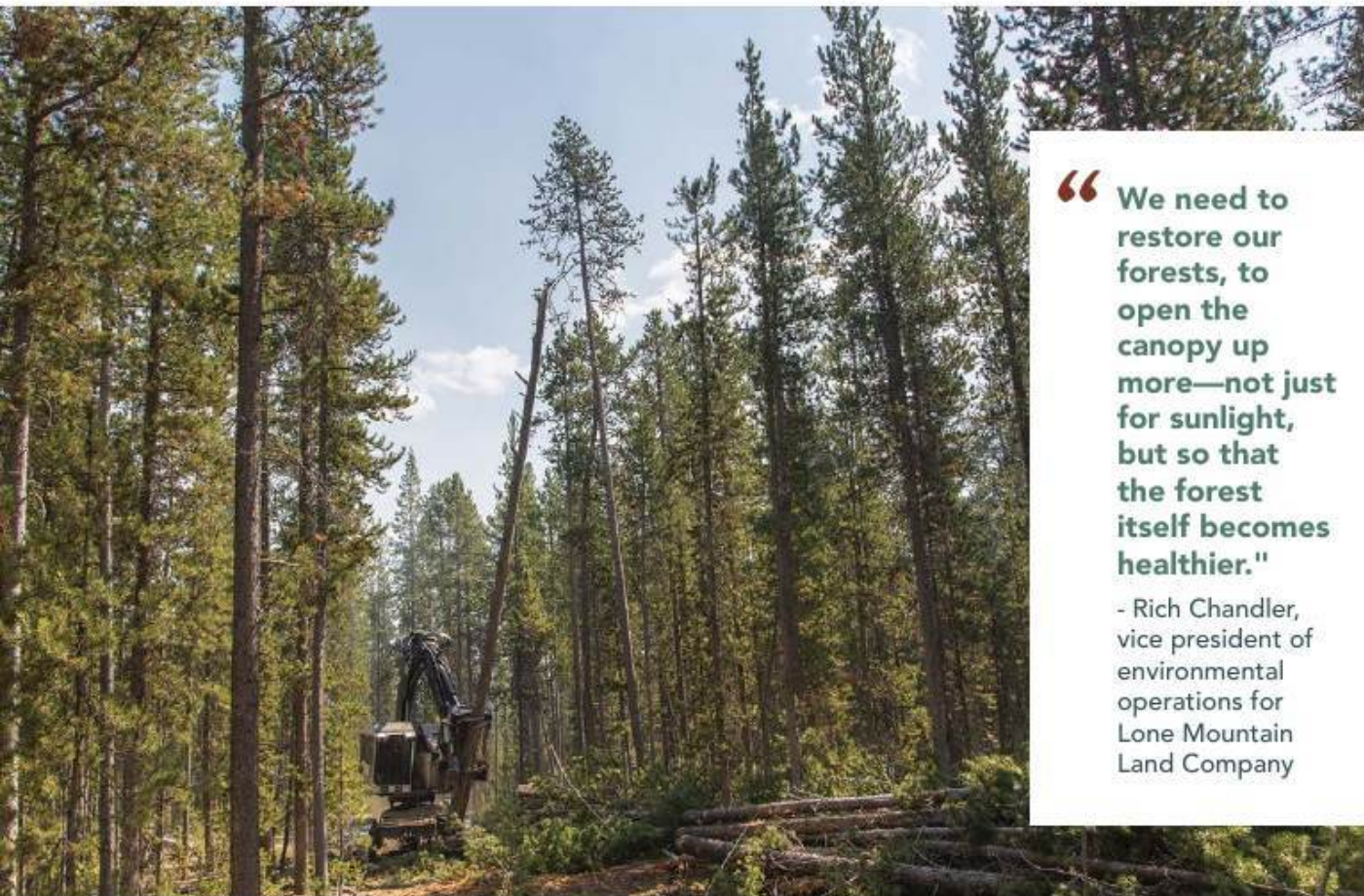
No one in the Rocky Mountain West should ever be arrogant about fire prevention. Awareness is key. For example, did you know that certain risk models suggest that Big Sky's wildfire risk is higher than 96% of communities in the U.S.?

Fire Adapted Big Sky, a working group of local and regional fire and forestry experts, is taking the lead in community outreach and education (their website alone is teeming with resources). Fire Adapted Big Sky's tagline expresses its mission: "Be Informed, Be Educated, Be Prepared." Resources range from current risk conditions to detailed information about fortifying homes and businesses against wildfire—including the option of a wildfire-preparedness site visit—to an opt-in alert system and evacuation map should fire threaten the community.

Big Sky offers several ways to opt in to the alert system, known as Everbridge. You can enroll via Fire Adapted Big Sky or scan a QR code, which you may have seen on local fliers or the Gallatin County trailer that's ever-present at the farmers market and summer concert series.

Visitors can also simply text **BIGSKY** to **888777** to receive emergency notifications.

Brett Edelman, with Billings attack crew, monitors the Buffalo Fire at Slough Creek. *Photograph courtesy of US National Park Service, Neil Herbert*



“ We need to restore our forests, to open the canopy up more—not just for sunlight, but so that the forest itself becomes healthier.”

- Rich Chandler,
vice president of
environmental
operations for
Lone Mountain
Land Company

As part of the fuels treatment program, a feller buncher thins trees near West Yellowstone in order to reduce threat of wildfire. *Photography courtesy of US National Park Service, Neil Herbert*

RESTORE, RESTORE, RESTORE

The 1910 fire that swept through the Big Sky area ultimately burned more than 3 million acres—the largest wildfire in U.S. history. In turn, it prompted a shift in firefighting philosophy. “Fire on the landscape used to be considered normal,” says Rich Chandler, vice president of environmental operations for Lone Mountain Land Company. “Well understood and accepted. But since then, a lot of the approach has been focused around suppression, suppression, suppression. So we have mature forests around Big Sky and those that burned which are more than 100 years old.”

In firefighting parlance, those forests are known, ominously, as “fuel.” Same goes for clearcuts from the late 1970s and ’80s. These forests, according to Chandler, are overcrowded to the point of having three or four times the density of trees than normal.

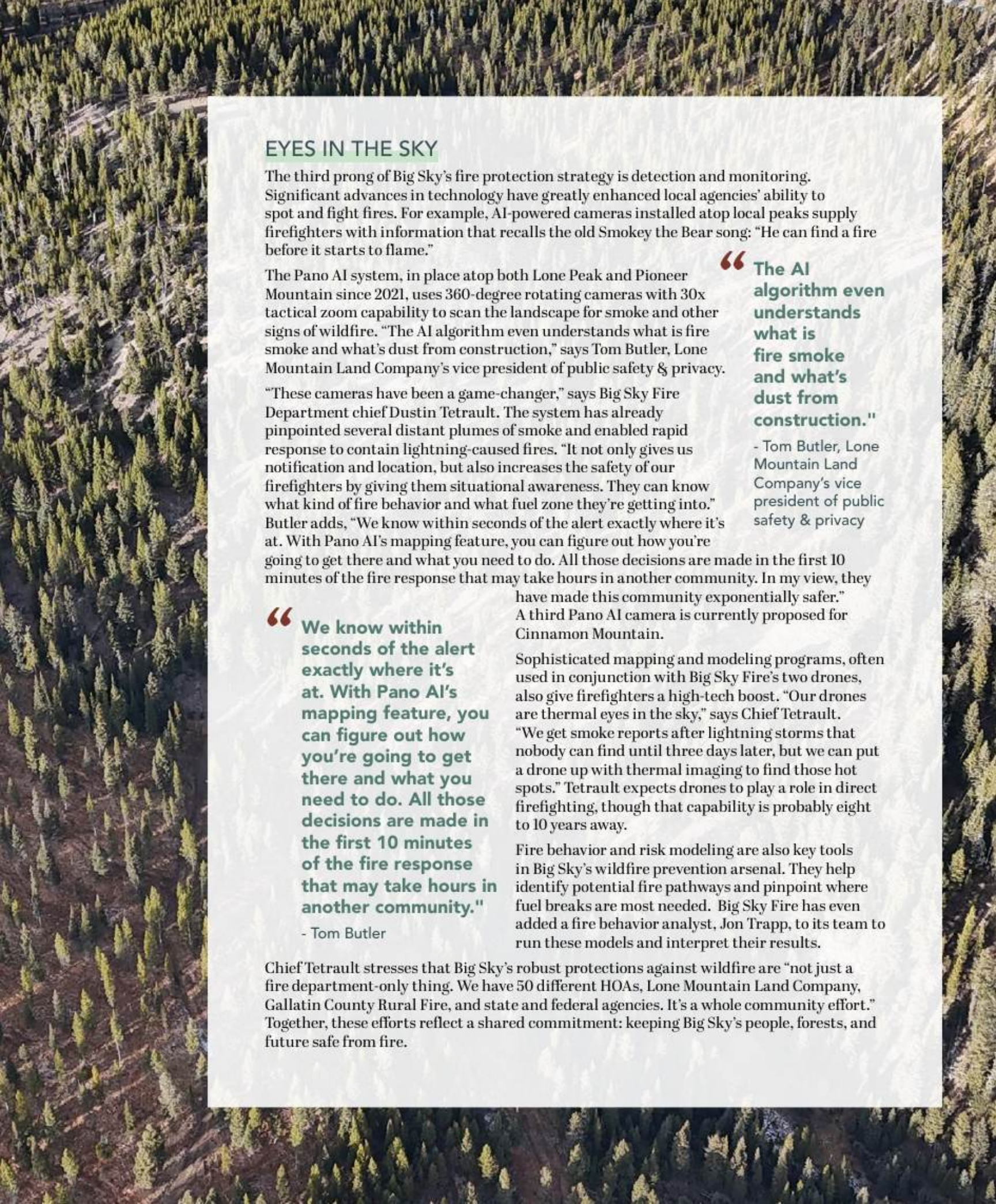
The cure is restoration. “We need to restore our forests, to open the canopy up more—not just for sunlight, but so that the forest itself becomes healthier,” says Chandler. “Then preferred species stay on the landscape, and the byproduct is reducing catastrophic wildfire. It creates what we call ‘defensibility,’ specifically by creating more separation between tree stands. And it helps to

bring a crown fire back down to the ground, which is easier for suppression efforts to fight.”

Yellowstone Club began this effort in the mid-2010s. Since then, Lone Mountain Land Company has implemented mitigation projects throughout Big Sky’s 50,000 private acres. “We now have active forestry fuel mitigation plans for each one of our communities to the tune of 10 to 12 projects this year, and north of a million dollars in total expenses,” says Chandler. “That’s a massive investment that we’ve made in our landscape. It’s given us more defensibility in the face of any potential wildfires that are either within our land, or from a trespass fire that may come from adjacent Forest Service lands into Big Sky.”

These programs, along with the outreach efforts of Fire Adapted Big Sky, have earned Yellowstone Club recognition as a Firewise Community from the Firewise USA program. Firewise USA bestows this honor on communities that have worked collaboratively to create a fire-resistant environment through landscaping, incorporating ignition-resistant materials and developing emergency response plans. Moonlight Basin and Spanish Peaks are working towards similar accreditations.

An aerial view of the greater Big Sky landscape. *Photograph courtesy of Lone Mountain Land Company*



EYES IN THE SKY

The third prong of Big Sky's fire protection strategy is detection and monitoring. Significant advances in technology have greatly enhanced local agencies' ability to spot and fight fires. For example, AI-powered cameras installed atop local peaks supply firefighters with information that recalls the old Smokey the Bear song: "He can find a fire before it starts to flame."

The Pano AI system, in place atop both Lone Peak and Pioneer Mountain since 2021, uses 360-degree rotating cameras with 30x tactical zoom capability to scan the landscape for smoke and other signs of wildfire. "The AI algorithm even understands what is fire smoke and what's dust from construction," says Tom Butler, Lone Mountain Land Company's vice president of public safety & privacy.

"These cameras have been a game-changer," says Big Sky Fire Department chief Dustin Tetrault. The system has already pinpointed several distant plumes of smoke and enabled rapid response to contain lightning-caused fires. "It not only gives us notification and location, but also increases the safety of our firefighters by giving them situational awareness. They can know what kind of fire behavior and what fuel zone they're getting into." Butler adds, "We know within seconds of the alert exactly where it's at. With Pano AI's mapping feature, you can figure out how you're going to get there and what you need to do. All those decisions are made in the first 10 minutes of the fire response that may take hours in another community. In my view, they

"We know within seconds of the alert exactly where it's at. With Pano AI's mapping feature, you can figure out how you're going to get there and what you need to do. All those decisions are made in the first 10 minutes of the fire response that may take hours in another community."

- Tom Butler

"The AI algorithm even understands what is fire smoke and what's dust from construction."

- Tom Butler, Lone Mountain Land Company's vice president of public safety & privacy

have made this community exponentially safer." A third Pano AI camera is currently proposed for Cinnamon Mountain.

Sophisticated mapping and modeling programs, often used in conjunction with Big Sky Fire's two drones, also give firefighters a high-tech boost. "Our drones are thermal eyes in the sky," says Chief Tetrault. "We get smoke reports after lightning storms that nobody can find until three days later, but we can put a drone up with thermal imaging to find those hot spots." Tetrault expects drones to play a role in direct firefighting, though that capability is probably eight to 10 years away.

Fire behavior and risk modeling are also key tools in Big Sky's wildfire prevention arsenal. They help identify potential fire pathways and pinpoint where fuel breaks are most needed. Big Sky Fire has even added a fire behavior analyst, Jon Trapp, to its team to run these models and interpret their results.

Chief Tetrault stresses that Big Sky's robust protections against wildfire are "not just a fire department-only thing. We have 50 different HOAs, Lone Mountain Land Company, Gallatin County Rural Fire, and state and federal agencies. It's a whole community effort." Together, these efforts reflect a shared commitment: keeping Big Sky's people, forests, and future safe from fire.



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WHAT'S IN A NAME?

**Bobcat vs. Grizzly:
Rivalry off the Lone Moose chairlift***Story by Gordy Megroz**Photography by Ryan Turner*

AT BIG SKY, EVEN THE TRAIL SIGNS TELL STORIES. On a quiet corner of the mountain called Lone Moose Meadows, two neighboring runs—Bobcat and Grizzly—hint at both the area's history and, perhaps, Montana's most famous rivalry. Were they named for college mascots or for the animals that still roam these forests? Turns out, a little bit of both.

Bobcat

It's probably not a shock to know that Bobcat, which is about 50 miles from Montana State University in Bozeman, is named for the school's mascot. At least that's the story. The land under the Lone Moose triple chair,

“

A lot of people avoid it because you need to ride a long, slow triple chair to ski it, so you can usually find stashes of fresh snow out there when you can't find them anywhere else.”

BRIT BARNES,
longtime Big Sky skier

where Bobcat is located, was originally owned by Tim Blixseth, the founder of Yellowstone Club. The trail was cut in the late 1990s, during the time Blixseth owned the land, and although he had no personal connection to Montana State, it's thought that the name was a tip of the cap to the college. “There are lots of students and alumni who ski at Big Sky and so that trail is probably named in honor of them,” says Dave Stergar, a former guide and 35-year Big Sky skier. Bobcat is a long, off-camber run with a steady pitch just under 30 degrees. It stays shaded thanks to northern exposure, and it's never groomed. “I go out there when everything else is skied off,” says Brit Barnes, another long-time Big Sky skier. “A lot of people avoid it because you need to ride a long, slow triple chair to ski it, so you can usually find stashes of fresh snow out there when you can't find them anywhere else.” That makes it ideal for powder hunters, unless you went to the University of Montana. According to local lore, if you're a Grizzly—UM's mascot—you're prohibited from skiing the trail.

Skier Brit Barnes making the most of a powder day off the Lone Moose chairlift, where untouched snow often greets skiers willing to make the trek over to Bobcat and Grizzly.



You can honor
the rivalry or
you can ski the
powder. Here,
Jed Donnelly
chooses the
latter, and it's
easy to see why.

Grizzly

Given that Bobcat is right next to Grizzly, and that the Grizzly is the mascot of Montana State's rival school, the University of Montana, one might deduce that Grizzly is named after the mascot. But that's not the case. In fact, from the time it opened in 1999 until 2011, it was called Grizzly Bear. The name comes from the large number of grizzly bears in the area. Despite that, the rules of local lore apply: If you went to Montana State, you're not supposed to ski Grizzly. If Bobcats stick to those rules, they're missing out. The run

is shorter but steeper than Bobcat, making for some fun descents, especially on powder days. "It's really a powder stash over there," says Stergar. "It's definitely someplace I like to go to find fresh turns." Stergar didn't go to either of the rival colleges, but even if he did, he says it wouldn't stop him from skiing both. "It's kind of a commitment to get over there," he says. "So if you're there, you might as well ski both Bobcat and Grizzly. Even if you went to MSU, Grizzly is just too fun not to ski. I don't think anybody will be too upset about it."

“

It's really a
powder stash
over there.
It's definitely
someplace I like
to go to find
fresh turns.”

—
DAVE STERGAR,
former guide and
35-year Big Sky Skier



Rivalries aside, the truth is that both runs deliver what skiers come to Big Sky for: solitude, powder, and a sense of history carved into the slope. The slopes don't care which team you root for. They're just waiting for you to make your turns.

HIGH
COUNTRY
Butterflies

Exploring the butterflies
that call Big Sky home and
the science behind their
high-alpine resilience.

Story by Helen Olsson

SOME PEOPLE GET SQUEAMISH around stinging, biting, or terrifying-looking insects. But butterflies, with their brightly colored gossamer wings and fuzzy bodies, are beloved. As they flit across a wildflower-filled meadow, they seem to have more in common with fairies than creepy-crawlies.

"Butterflies are a great way to engage people with nature and to help them understand how important insects are," says Dr. Diane Debinski, a Montana State University ecology professor and co-author of *A Field Guide to Butterflies of the Greater Yellowstone Ecosystem* (Roberts Rinehart, 2002).

"BUTTERFLIES ARE A GREAT WAY TO ENGAGE PEOPLE WITH NATURE AND TO HELP THEM UNDERSTAND HOW IMPORTANT INSECTS ARE." – Dr. Diane Debinski,
Montana State University ecology professor

About 100 butterfly species live around Big Sky. Most spend their lifetimes in the Greater Yellowstone Ecosystem, and only

a few are migratory. You see the butterflies in summer, but for the rest of the seasons, they overwinter in immature stages as eggs, larvae, or pupae, and are cozy in a blanket of snow, in tree bark, or in the soil. "They're all there, just invisible, unless you know what to look for," Debinski says.

To adapt to Montana's cold, harsh winters and high elevation, some butterflies have darker wings to attract the sun's warm rays. Butterflies are "solar-powered," meaning their muscles need to warm up before they can fly. (The technical term is "heliotropism.") And in their caterpillar stage, they may feed on only one particular high-alpine plant. Debinski notes that climate change has the potential to impact a butterfly's survival. If their insulating snow blanket thaws and melts, vulnerable eggs might die in a subsequent freeze. A changing climate could cause asynchrony, a mismatch between plant and butterfly. A flower might bloom before a butterfly emerges to feed on its nectar.

We asked Debinski to share a few notable species that live in Big Sky.

Heliotropism is the tendency of an organism to turn or grow toward sunlight. With butterflies, this describes their behavioral response of basking in the sun to warm their bodies for flight and navigation. As cold-blooded (ectothermic) insects, butterflies rely on external heat sources to function.



MOURNING CLOAK
Nymphalis antiopa

MOURNING CLOAK

Nymphalis antiopa

With velvety maroon wings edged in yellow, Montana's state butterfly is one of the first to appear in spring in woodlands and along streams. In winter, the butterfly lives as an adult in the hollows of trees, camouflaged against the bark. The Mourning Cloak caterpillar feeds on willows, while the butterfly prefers rotting fruit over nectar.



CLODIUS PARNASSIAN
Parnassius clodius

CLODIUS PARNASSIAN

Parnassius clodius

In its caterpillar form, Clodius Parnassian feeds only on Steer's Head (*Dicentra uniflora*), a rare subalpine plant with small pink flowers shaped like cow heads. "There's a very tight relationship between the host plant and *Parnassius clodius*," Debinski says. You'll find this swallowtail butterfly—its white, semi-transparent wings dotted with black, red, and yellow spots—flying near the treeline. *P. clodius* forages for nectar on Sulphur Flower Buckwheat, a plant with a generous landing pad.



YELLOWSTONE CHECKERSPOT
Euphydryas gillettii

YELLOWSTONE CHECKERSPOT

Euphydryas gillettii

Considered a "species of concern," the Yellowstone Checkerspot (also called Gillett's Checkerspot) is relatively rare and is part of a group of butterflies called checkerspots, which are often studied by scientists. This medium-sized orange and black butterfly eats and lays its eggs exclusively on the black twinberry, a shrub found in wet meadows at the forest's edge. Chasing this one with a butterfly net is generally frowned upon.



PAINTED LADY
Vanessa cardui

PAINTED LADY

Vanessa cardui

Most Big Sky butterflies don't migrate. The Painted Lady, a pinkish-tawny butterfly that feeds on thistles, is an exception. In mild winters, it might hibernate, but it's known to migrate long distances to destinations in the southwestern U.S., southern Florida, and Mexico.



VICEROY
Limenitis archippus

VICEROY

Limenitis archippus

"Whenever people see an orange and black butterfly, they think they've spotted a monarch," Debinski says. They probably haven't because monarchs are rarely found in the Yellowstone area. The Viceroy mimics the monarch, but it's smaller and has a single row of white spots on its hind wings. Unlike Monarchs, Viceroy's have a dark black line across their hind wings.



HAYDEN'S RINGLET
Coenonympha haydeni

HAYDEN'S RINGLET

Coenonympha haydeni

Named after Yellowstone's 1871 Hayden Expedition, this butterfly lives only in the Greater Yellowstone Ecosystem. "It's a shy, reclusive butterfly that is not very showy, and it doesn't live anywhere else in the whole world," says Debinski, who's fond enough of this particular winged creature to name her own son Hayden.

Next time

a butterfly crosses your path on a summer hike, pause to watch. Behind those bright wings lies a story of adaptation, connection, and the fragile magic that makes Big Sky's wild places thrive.



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Big Lines with Moonlight Ambassador **Parkin Costain.**

Parkin Costain wears a lot of hats: Moonlight Basin ambassador, pro freeride skier, pro snowmobiler, pro mountain biker, Teton Gravity Research film star—the list goes on and on. Based in Big Sky, he goes wherever the action is. Take a look.



Buck Ridge snowmobiling in Big Sky.
Photograph by Jonathan Finch



Ripping Double
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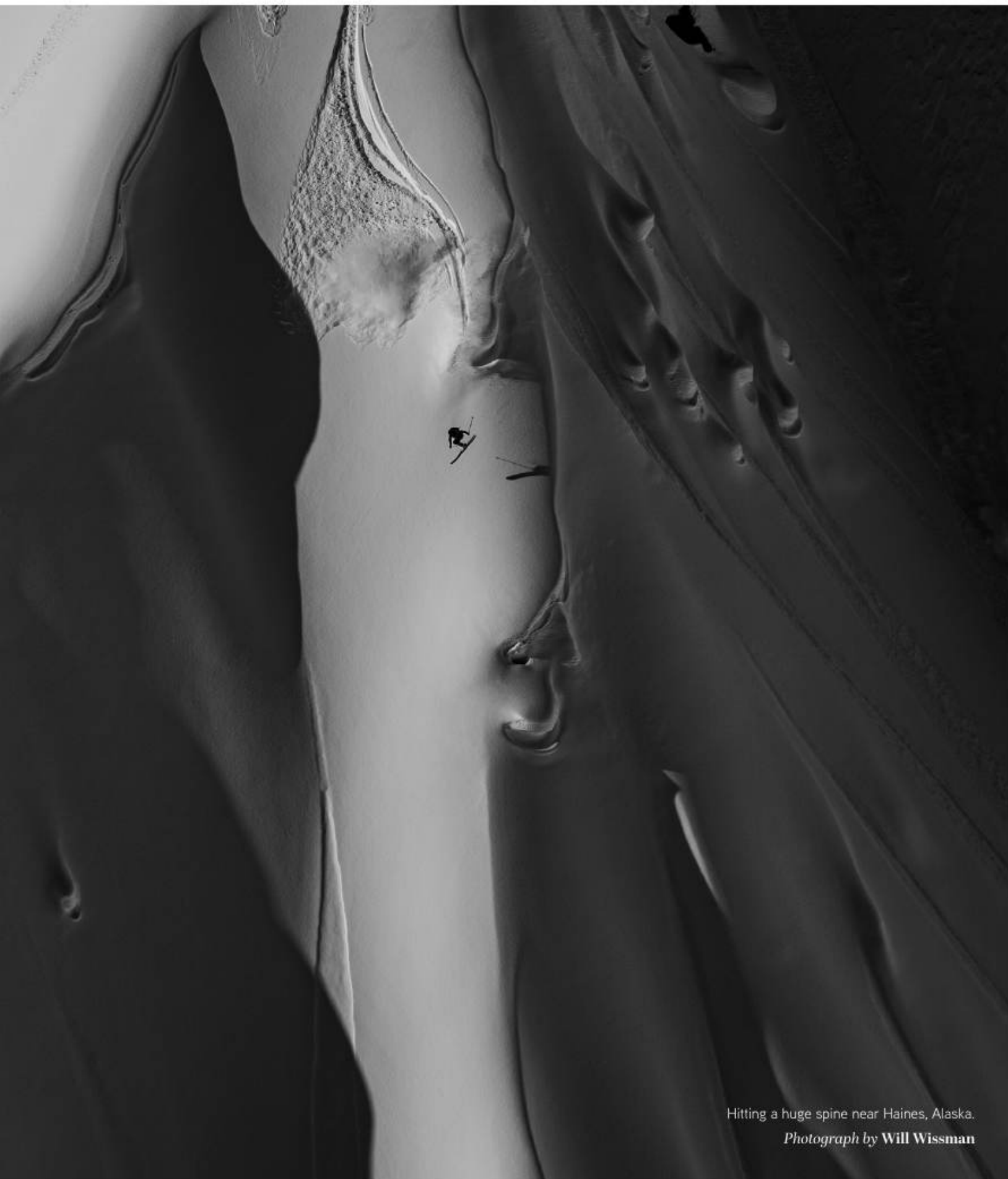
Photograph by
Kene Sperry



Going big into Corbet's
Couloir at the Kings & Queens
competition in Jackson Hole.

Photograph by **Mitchell Bryan**





Hitting a huge spine near Haines, Alaska.

Photograph by Will Wissman



Going big on the bike in Virgin, Utah.

Photograph by **Jonathan Finch**



Skiing some secret pillows
in No Name, Montana
Photograph by Andrew Chad

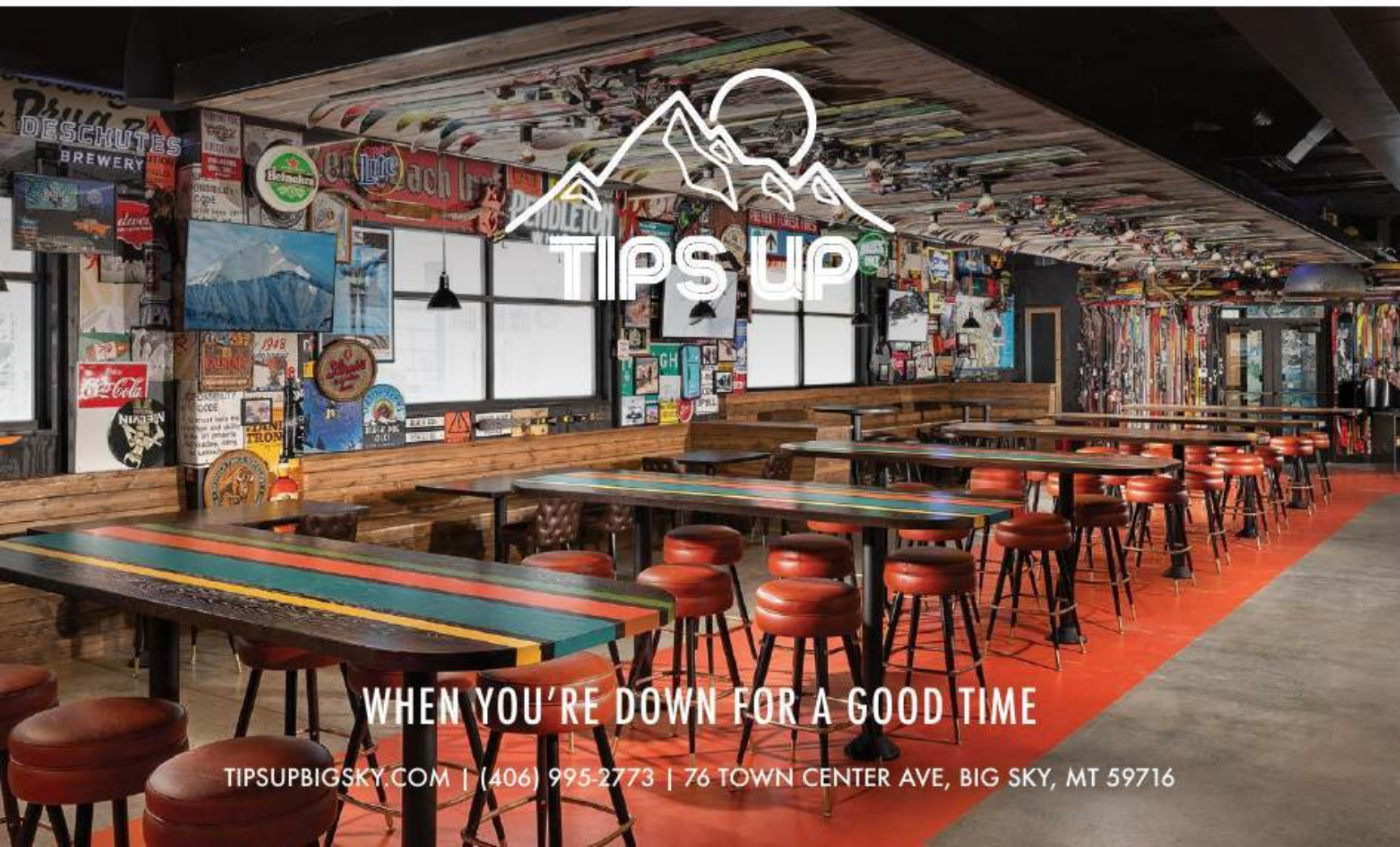
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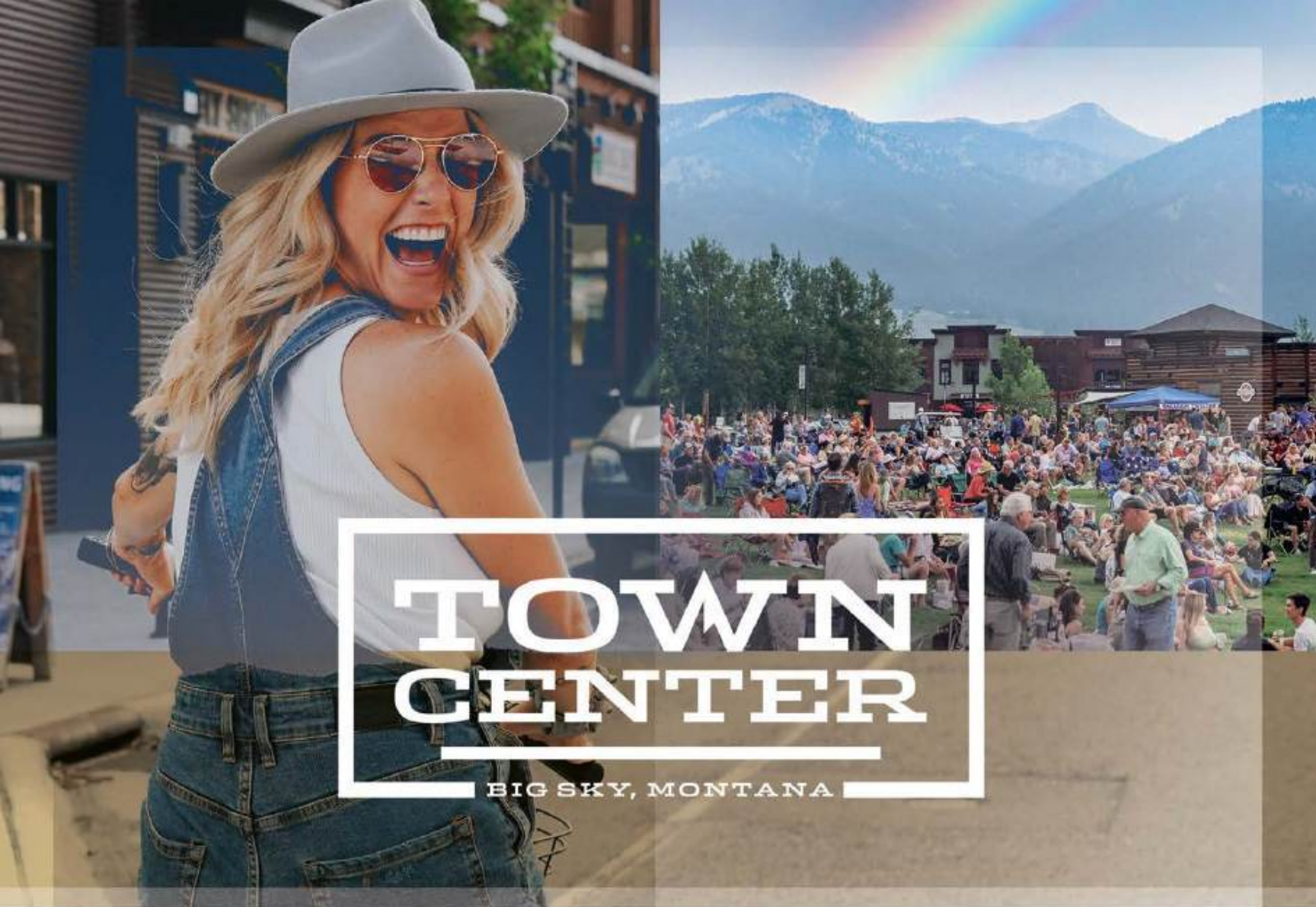
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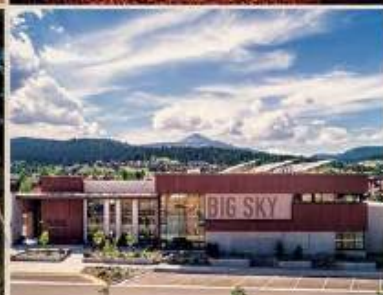
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The Lone Peak Tram rises toward the Kircliff scenic viewing platform atop Lone Peak. Brand new for the 2025/26 season, the platform now stands as the highest scenic outlook in the state. Its glass walls frame views of several surrounding mountain ranges and, on clear days, Yellowstone National Park. *Photograph courtesy of Big Sky Resort*

A glass observation deck at the top of Lone Peak, the world's fastest 10-person gondola, a Michelin-starred chef residency, and more.

Story by Maggie Slepian

A DECADE AFTER UNVEILING ITS BIG SKY 2025 VISION, Big Sky Resort's long-planned improvements are now fully taking shape. The initiative set out to elevate every touchpoint of the mountain experience, from arrival in the village to the summit of Lone Peak. The 2025/26 season marks its culmination.



EVEN BEFORE ACQUIRING MOONLIGHT BASIN IN 2013, Big Sky was already one of the country's most beloved mountain destinations, but the past decade has deepened its character and refined the experience of the mountain itself. The resort now spans 5,850 acres with more than 300 trails and 40 lifts, complemented by new high-speed access, reimagined dining, and an expanded summer mountain biking network. Recent updates include high-elevation dining with panoramic views, a mid-mountain learning zone, refreshed restaurants, and a two-story glass viewing platform atop Lone Peak, along with a four-month residency with a Michelin-starred chef and a new high-speed gondola for the 2025/26 season.

Here's what to look for during your visit to Big Sky Resort this year.

66

KIRCLIFF WAS CREATED TO TRANSFORM LONE PEAK INTO A YEAR-ROUND, MUST-VISIT DESTINATION AND TO CREATE AN ACCESSIBLE WAY TO EXPERIENCE ONE OF THE REGION'S HIGHEST PEAKS."

- TROY NEDVED,
president and chief operating officer of Big Sky Resort



A marvel of alpine engineering, the Kircliff platform cantilevers dramatically over the edge of Lone Peak. It was designed to create an accessible, year-round way to experience Big Sky's highest summit. *Photograph courtesy of Big Sky Resort*

KIRCLIFF SCENIC VIEWING PLATFORM THE PEAK OF BIG SKY'S 2025 VISION

Silhouetted against the Montana sky with the hum of the Lone Peak Tram in the background, the soaring 3,200-square-foot Kircliff scenic viewing platform appears striking against the alpine landscape. Walls of glass frame Lone Peak's fall line, overlooking several mountain ranges at once: the Madisons, Gallatins, Absarokas, the Beartooths, and the Tetons. On a clear day, the southern horizon includes views of Yellowstone National Park.

SITTING AT 11,166 FEET,
THIS GLASS STRUCTURE
REPRESENTS THE
KIRCHER FAMILY'S LONG-
STANDING VISION FOR
BIG SKY RESORT.

Sitting at 11,166 feet, this glass structure represents the Kircher family's long-standing vision for Big Sky Resort—a continuation of their legacy as owners of Boyne Resorts, which acquired the mountain in 1976. A marvel of alpine engineering, it cantilevers dramatically over the edge of the peak and now stands as the highest scenic outlook in the state.

While the viewing station officially took shape this past spring, its foundations—and the vision behind them—have been in place since 2022. Construction on the terminal foundation began in 2022, and it was intentionally designed to one day support the viewing platform above. The platform itself was completed in December 2023, with the building finished during the summer of 2025.

"Kircliff was created to transform Lone Peak into a year-round, must-visit destination and to create an accessible way to experience one of the region's highest peaks," says Troy Nedved, Big Sky Resort's president and chief operating officer. "It gives every guest the opportunity to reach the summit and witness panoramic views stretching from Yellowstone to the Tetons."

Even reaching Kircliff is part of the experience. Starting at the base of the resort, viewers ride the new Explorer Gondola to 9,000 feet in elevation—1,000 feet above the top of the original Explorer chairlift. The journey continues aboard the Lone Peak Tram, which climbs more than 2,000 vertical feet in just four minutes. The entire ride is smooth and fast, taking a mere 15 minutes from base to 11,166 feet—the top of Lone Peak, where Kircliff awaits.

The Kircliff viewing station connects directly to the Lone Peak Tram's upper terminal via a short walkway. Inside, visitors are surrounded by sweeping, floor-to-ceiling views on every side of the two-story glass deck, with a transparent floor revealing the slope below. Designers minimized steel elements to preserve the sense of openness while maintaining structural strength. The result is a breathtaking perch that seems to suspend visitors above Lone Peak's rugged expanse.

Kircliff's opening marks the first time visitors on foot can take in the view from this lofty height. Previously reserved only for skiers or hikers willing to trek to its slopes, the new access features ADA accommodations, and the Explorer Gondola eliminates the short hike or ski previously required to access the tram.

Scenic tickets to Kircliff cost \$30 per person, with a family four-pack available at a discount. Tickets are good for all-day non-skier access on the Explorer Gondola and Lone Peak Tram, and skiers or snowboarders can access Kircliff by riding the Lone Peak Tram with their lift tickets as long as they've purchased tram access.

Kircliff is a cornerstone of the Big Sky 2025 vision. Paired with the new Explorer Gondola, Kircliff provides visitors, skiers, and snowboarders with an epic experience from base to summit.

If you're coming from sea level, note that Kircliff sits above 11,000 feet, and the air will feel quite thin. It's fully enclosed, but the resort recommends dressing warmly and wearing comfortable shoes or insulated winter boots.

HIGH-SPEED EXPLORER GONDOLA REPLACES FORMER EXPLORER CHAIRLIFT

Brand new for the season with a grand opening of December 20, 2025, the Explorer Gondola is now the world's fastest 10-person gondola. The new gondola launches from Mountain Village at the base of the resort. The completion of this gondola creates a crucial link between the base and the Lone Peak Tram and replaces the former Explorer 2 Chair with updated speed, access, world-class comfort, and transitions between lifts. Skiers and boarders can now access high-elevation terrain via Lone Peak Tram in fast-moving comfort, or hop off midway for trails on moderate and beginner-friendly terrain. And for Kircliff visitors, the Explorer Gondola provides the connection from the Big Sky base to the tram and viewing station.

Guests riding the new gondola will travel in custom Omega V cabins that seat up to ten people and are fully enclosed with floor-to-ceiling windows and heated

seats for the ride up the mountain. Designed by the Doppelmayr Group, the 83 cabins balance comfort and function with exterior racks, interior gear holders, and wide-open views in every direction. In the summer, 19 bike-friendly cabins will join the fleet and give riders direct access to Big Sky's downhill trails.

The new lift has the capacity to bring 2,850 skiers per hour up the mountain at speeds up to 15 miles per hour. The ride takes less than 10 minutes from Big Sky's base to the upper terminal. The gondola runs in two stages along its 8,536-foot route from base to bowl and allows access to Kircliff and the summit of Lone Peak in just a few minutes.

The new gondola replaces the Explorer 2 Chair, the last of Big Sky's original 1973 lifts. Its historic chairs were auctioned off in 2025 and raised more than \$150,000 for local nonprofits.



The new Explorer Gondola opens easier access to northern Swift Current 6 terrain and adds a mid-station at 8,263 feet that will soon house Big Sky's Ski School.
Photograph courtesy of Big Sky Resort



The new Explorer Gondola, the world's fastest 10-person gondola, which opened on December 20, 2025. *Photograph courtesy of Big Sky Resort*

“

THE TIME HAD COME TO REPLACE THE EXPLORER 2 CHAIR, AND WE'RE PROUD TO HAVE THE MOST TECHNOLOGICALLY ADVANCED LIFT NETWORK IN NORTH AMERICA."

- TROY NEDVED

"The time had come to replace the Explorer 2 Chair, and we're proud to have the most technologically advanced lift network in North America," says Nedved. "The new gondola brings a huge improvement in comfort and speed, matching the quality of our other lifts."

Rising 1,000 feet higher than the original line, the new gondola opens easier access to northern Swift Current 6 terrain. A mid-station at 8,263 feet will soon house Big Sky's Ski School, easing base-area congestion. When completed, the Explorer Gondola became the thirteenth new lift in a decade, underscoring the resort's ongoing push to enhance access and comfort across the mountain.



(above) Architectural renderings of M by The Alinea Group's Big Sky residency. Fettle Design created a space that reflects both the craft of modernist cuisine and the wild terrain that defines Big Sky.

(right) A fresh expression of chef-driven dining for those who savor extraordinary culinary experiences.

Photography courtesy of Big Sky Resort



CULINARY ICON GRANT ACHATZ TAKES RESIDENCY AT BIG SKY RESORT WITH M BY THE ALINEA GROUP

During the 2025/26 season, Big Sky Resort will welcome one of the world's most celebrated chefs to the mountains. Michelin-starred Chef Grant Achatz and his team from The Alinea Group will bring their internationally acclaimed dining concept, M by The Alinea Group, to Big Sky for a four-month residency, making it one of only five stops of a global tour celebrating The Alinea Group's 20th anniversary alongside Tokyo, Miami, Beverly Hills, and Brooklyn. Each residency features a menu designed exclusively for its location, shaped by local ingredients and the rhythm of the season.

Founded in Chicago in 2005, The Alinea Group has become a global leader in modernist cuisine and has earned four Michelin Stars and multiple James Beard Awards across restaurants including Alinea, Next, The Aviary, and The Office. Now, that same inventive spirit finds a new home in Montana high country.

The partnership began after members of Big Sky's team dined at Alinea in Chicago and began discussing possibilities with The Alinea Group's CEO. Those conversations evolved into a collaboration to bring Chef Grant Achatz to the resort and create a dining experience unlike anything found at a ski destination.

"When The Alinea Group told us they wanted to create something transformational in a place that matched their own spirit of innovation, we knew they understood what Big Sky represents," chief executive officer and president of Boyne Resorts Stephen Kircher said.

Chef Grant Achatz is an internationally celebrated chef known for his immersive dining experience and innovative cuisine. After overcoming stage 4 tongue cancer, Chef Achatz was named Best Chef in the United States by the James Beard Foundation. He has been awarded numerous other honors, including being named one of Time Magazine's 100 Most Influential People, a feature on Netflix's Chef's Table and earning more than a decade of consecutive Michelin stars.

M by The Alinea Group occupies the space once home to Andiamo Italian Grille. The award-winning Fettle Design led the transformation and created an atmosphere that pairs European culinary precision with the raw beauty of Montana's alpine landscape. Rather than simply transplanting the Alinea experience, the team envisioned a concept shaped by the mountain environment and the spirit of winter itself. Each dish is crafted with intention and showcases seasonal, locally sourced ingredients.

"For a resort that has always thrived at the intersection of wild terrain and world-class innovation, this residency represents a bold step forward in defining the future of mountain hospitality," says Nedved.

This marks Big Sky's first chef residency, though the team hints it may not be the last. For now, this four-month winter residency runs from December 19, 2025 until March 31, 2026.

“

WHEN THE ALINEA GROUP TOLD US THEY WANTED TO CREATE SOMETHING TRANSFORMATIONAL IN A PLACE THAT MATCHED THEIR OWN SPIRIT OF INNOVATION, WE KNEW THEY UNDERSTOOD WHAT BIG SKY REPRESENTS.”

- STEPHEN KIRCHER,
president and chief executive
officer of Boyne Resorts



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MISADVENTURES IN YELLOWSTONE NATIONAL PARK

TRAGEDY, MYSTERY, AND MISSTEPS

Story by Helen Olsson

In 1871, Truman Everts was separated from an early Yellowstone expedition and lost in the wilderness for over

a month. He subsisted on thistles, scalded himself in a hot spring, and was stalked by a mountain lion. Still, he waxed poetic about the park in a Scribner's Monthly article titled "37 Days of Peril." "The ascending vapor from innumerable hot springs, and the sparkling jet of a single geyser, added the feature of novelty to one of the grandest landscapes I ever beheld."

That is the allure of wild spaces like Yellowstone National Park. Bubbling mud pots, waterfalls plunging over crimson cliffs, the gemstone hues of a hot spring. These moments have the power to elevate the human soul. But those same elements also have the power to kill. Since the park was established in 1872, most deaths can be attributed to car accidents and illness, but visitors have met their maker in a multitude of other ways: drowning in Yellowstone Lake, scalded in a 200° thermal pool, gored



Portrait of Truman C. Everts, Helena, Montana, circa 1870.

Photograph courtesy of Project Gutenberg's "Thirty-Seven Days of Peril" by Truman Everts, public domain.

by a seemingly tame bison, mauled by a grizzly, caught in avalanches, and more.

"People are drawn to these vast landscapes. We have 2.2 million acres and hundreds of miles of trails, but there are also roads and hotels," says Yellowstone Park historian Alicia Murphy. "That element of civilization leads people to sometimes underestimate the risks."

Over the years, accidents have sparked debates around the National Park Service's responsibility to protect visitors. The high-profile case of nine-year-old Andy Hecht, who fell into a hot pool in 1970, led to a multiyear campaign to change NPS policy around marking hazards.

Today, in developed thermal areas, warning signs pepper boardwalks and park rangers hand out informational and cautionary literature at entrance gates. "You put too many signs up, and you start impeding on Yellowstone's beauty," Murphy says. Warnings or no, people cannot resist the temptation to touch the steaming waters or to approach the massive bison.

We searched through newspaper archives, NPS incident reports, and park historian Lee Whittlesey's iconic book *Death in Yellowstone* (2014) to find stories of misadventures in the park: the strange, the unexplained, the poetic, the tragic. We hope these accounts serve as reminders that nature doesn't need taming—just a healthy dose of respect and, in the case of large wildlife, a wide berth. Many of these situations could have been avoided with a touch of common sense and a thoughtful appreciation for the maxim, "look, don't touch."



A tally-ho stagecoach loaded with passengers being pulled down the road by a six-horse team in the Gardiner Canyon between Mammoth and Gardiner. People can be seen sitting on the roof of the stagecoach, 1908. Photograph courtesy of R. Steinman & Co. Publishers, MT History Portal

HORSES AND STAGECOACHES

When the park first opened, travel was mainly by horse and stagecoach; the automobile wasn't introduced until 1915. In 1908, W. L. Escher, an Idaho bookkeeper, was traveling by mountain wagon with his wife when the shotgun draped across his lap fell. Its hammers struck the wagon wheel, discharging both barrels into his chest. His wife spent the night fending off wildlife. *The Pocatello Tribune* ran the headline: "Guarded Her Husband's Dead Body from Coyotes and Timber Wolves." Two years later, a convoy of 30 stagecoaches was passing through the Hoodoos south of Mammoth Hot Springs when suddenly the road collapsed and one of the stagecoaches fell into a limestone cavern below. Daniel E. MacKay, a visitor from New York City, jumped from the coach, which then landed on top of him. He died soon after.

A B-17F bomber similar to the plane that crashed in 1943 near West Yellowstone. Photograph courtesy of U.S. Naval Aviation



As of 2013, at least eight airplane crashes (causing 22 deaths) have occurred in Yellowstone National Park.

AIRPLANE CRASHES

During World War II, more than 7,100 military aircraft crashed on American soil, often in remote mountainous areas inside national parks. In May 1943, a B-17 bomber crashed near West Yellowstone. When the pilot ordered a bailout, bombardier William F. McDonald, who was sleeping next to the nose hatch, rolled from the plane and pulled his ripcord, landing in a snowbank in the pitch dark. The sole survivor, McDonald was rescued three days later. During the 1988 forest fires, the wreck, which had been buried under decades of growth, was rediscovered. Crews removed 25,000 pounds of wreckage, including shards of rusted .50-caliber machine guns and the plane's wingtip.

From 1880 to 1916, stagecoach companies reported roughly four stagecoach wrecks per year in Yellowstone due to runaway horses, mechanical failures or drunk drivers. For more than four decades (1872-1915), early Yellowstone visitors traveled only by horseback or stagecoach. The automobile made its first appearance in 1915. The park was completely motorized by 1917. In the summer of 1917, 117 buses, each carrying between seven and 11 park visitors, replaced horses and stagecoaches.



Early visitors at Handkerchief Pool, Yellowstone National Park. Many years ago, one of the most famous attractions in Yellowstone was a small spring called Handkerchief Pool. Visitors threw dirty handkerchiefs into the water. The cloths were sucked into the depths, only to emerge a few minutes later, considerably cleaner. Other objects were also thrown into the hot spring, including coins, broken bottles, rocks, hair pins, and a small horseshoe. The plumbing system of Handkerchief Pool was damaged and eventually the spring became dormant. Today this hot spring has been nearly forgotten. Black Sand Basin, around 1923. *Photograph courtesy of U.S. National Park Service*

Since the park opened, 23 people have died from burns incurred by falling into the park's thermal features. In the summer of 2025, the Yellowstone National Park geology program team recovered 300 hats from the park's thermal features—as well as a Birkenstock sandal, a fake Louis Vuitton bucket hat, and a ball cap with the words, "I Pee in the Lake."

THERMAL POOLS

When a shoe with a human foot inside mysteriously surfaced in Yellowstone's Abyss pool in August 2022, the grisly find caught the nation's attention. Park officials connected the dots, leading to the unwitnessed death of a 70-year-old Californian man. Yellowstone has some 10,000 hot springs, geysers, mudpots, and steam vents scattered across the park—some as hot as 205°. Countless visitors have been injured, and more than 20 people have died in the park's thermal waters. People stumble, slip, or intentionally jump in. In July 2024, an SUV drove into the Semi-Centennial Geyser. The five passengers climbed out of the car and the geyser to safety, and the car was winched out from nine feet below the surface.

In 1905, Fannie A. Weeks, a clerk for the U.S. Treasury Department who was traveling by stagecoach, was standing at the edge of a crater dressed in black, a veil over her face. As the mist rose, she removed her smoked glasses to clean them. "The edge of one of the geysers gave

way with me and let me down into the boiling cauldron," she dictated in a letter from her hospital bed before succumbing to her injuries. Exacerbating her predicament, her layers of petticoats continued to burn her skin after she'd been pulled from the water.

In 1981, David Allen Kirwin and Ronald Ratliff were visiting the Fountain Paint Pots when Ratliff's dog, Moosie, jumped into Celestine Pool—ostensibly to cool off. Kirwin peeled off his shirt and dove in headfirst to rescue the dog. He was scalded instantly in the 202° waters. Emerging blind and with third-degree burns over 100% of his body, Kirwin uttered the realization: "That was a stupid thing I did." He died the next day.

In 2000, after spending the afternoon swimming in Firehole River, three Old Faithful Inn employees—recent high school graduates Lance Buchi and Tyler Montague and college junior Sara Hulphers—were heading back to their cars in the dark when they saw what they thought was a thin ribbon of water. Holding hands, they jumped over it,

but the water was an optical illusion. In reality, the three friends jumped onto an earthen bank that crumbled, sending them plunging into the depths of Cavern Spring. Perhaps because the water was only 178°, the boys survived; Hulphers died at the hospital.

Just when you think you've heard it all, a group of 10 visitors was caught attempting to use the park's thermal waters for cooking dinner in 2020. Rangers found the group and realized its members had immersed two whole chickens in a burlap sack in a hot spring near Shoshone Geyser Basin. The NPS issued a warning around such culinary adventures on its LEGO Vignettes Facebook page, showing a LEGO minifigure dunking a turkey into a colorful pool. "It is illegal to cook a turkey in the hot springs at Yellowstone National Park," read the post. "Boiled, baked, stewed, brined, spatchcocked, grilled, braised, smoked, and deep-fried are all illegal.... Just don't do it."

BISON

Whittlesey calls the bison a mythologized animal. "To many Yellowstone Park visitors, it is not a genuine living, breathing creature," he wrote in *Death in Yellowstone*. "It's a symbol of a vanished past." But bison are real. And dangerous. Scroll through the NPS's incident reports, and stories of visitors approaching bison and getting gored repeat endlessly. There are some 4,000 bison in the park, each weighing as much as 2,000 pounds. According to a 2019 report published in *Science Digest*, bison injure more people at Yellowstone than any other animal. Given the number of injuries that have occurred, it's miraculous, really, that only two people have been killed by bison since 1872.

In 1971, Marvin Lesley Schrader, 30, who was visiting the park with his wife and three children, walked within 20 feet of a solitary bull in a meadow east of Rush Lake to take its picture. Reports suggest that teenagers had been throwing rocks to get the bison to stand up. The one-ton beast charged Schrader, tossing him in the air and goring his abdomen. Tragically, his family watched him die. The park pamphlet they'd picked up warning of the dangers of wildlife went unheeded.

The common thread is visitors getting too close, often in pursuit of a great photo. Bison can be belligerent and unpredictable. In 2009, two tourists were using a pay phone near Canyon Lodge when a bull bison walked up behind them and butted the woman into the air. They never saw it coming.



A bison bull in Lamar Valley charging a dog, 1923. Photograph courtesy of U.S. National Park Service



Signage warning tourists not to approach wildlife. Photograph courtesy of U.S. National Park Service



A bison herd walks through snow in Lamar Valley. Photograph by Nathan Peterson

According to a 2019 report published in *Science Digest*, bison injure more people at Yellowstone than any other animal. Given the number of injuries that have occurred, it's miraculous, really, that only two people have been killed by bison since 1872.



"Lunch Counter—For Bears Only" at Old Faithful, southeast of the upper Hamilton Store, and Ranger Naturalist Walter Phillip Martindale. Photograph courtesy of U.S. National Park Service

BEARS

Today, Yellowstone is home to around 750 bears. And while there have been many injuries over the park's 150 years, only eight bear-related deaths have occurred. In 1916, Frank Welch was sleeping under a wagon when a grizzly attacked. The *Ogden Daily Standard* reported: "The bear dragged him from beneath the wagon and proceeded to eat him alive." A second man attempted to distract the bear by throwing chunks of bacon at it. The bear, according to Whittlesey, had been dubbed "Old Two Toes" after it was captured in 1912 in a 60-pound metal trap just outside the park. The trapper intended to use the grizzly for target practice, but the bear escaped from the trap—losing three toes in the process—and killed the trapper.

The bacon was just the beginning. For decades, bears were allowed to beg from cars and feed from the park's open-pit garbage dumps. In 1958, predator biologist John Craighead counted 88 grizzly bears feeding at the Trout Creek dump. The park hosted "bear shows," complete with wooden bleachers for viewing the nightly feeding frenzy. The shows were shut down in 1941, and the last dump was closed in 1970. By then, however, the bears had developed a taste for human food. Millions of tourists interacting closely with 400-pound

habituated bears was a disaster waiting to happen.

The 1972 death of 25-year-old Harry Walker, killed by a grizzly bear, sparked a civil trial that shaped park policy. Walker had hitchhiked into the park and camped on a hillside near Old Faithful. A 20-year-old, 232-pound sow with a history of feeding on garbage was drawn to food scattered at the campsite. The bear charged Walker and mauled him to death. Walker's parents sued the U.S. Department of the Interior for mismanagement of the park's grizzly bears. During the trial, the judge suggested campgrounds be fenced in for safety.

After years of bears panhandling from cars and feasting on garbage, human-bear conflicts had reached critical numbers. In the 1960s, there were 45 bear-related injuries in the park per year compared to just one injury per year by the 2000s. While the park had begun to address the bear problem prior to Walker's death, the case was a turning point. To protect both the bears and people, the park accelerated its implementation of a bear management strategy that included mitigating access to human food and garbage, educating visitors about the dangers of wildlife, and relocating or euthanizing problem bears.

Since Yellowstone National Park was established in 1872, eight people have been killed by bears in the park. The chances of being injured by a grizzly bear are approximately 1 in 2.7 million visits. (The risk is much lower for people who stay in developed areas.) Human injuries have decreased from an average of 45 per year in the 1960s to just 1 per year in the 2000s.

A man standing just off of a walking path at Camp Roosevelt in YNP. He is reaching inside something, likely pulling food scraps out to feed to the bear. The bear is on its hind legs, reaching towards the man, 1925. Photograph courtesy of U.S. National Park Service





Lightning strikes and sunset at Swan Lake flat.
Photograph by Neal Herbert with U.S. National Park Service

LIGHTNING

In 1885, a U.S. Geological Survey party set out in a sailboat on Yellowstone Lake. It was a warm day, the skies mostly clear. As they floated 100 yards from the shore, a massive thunderclap sounded. Lightning struck the boat's mast, rendering all four men aboard unconscious. When topographer John H. Renshaw awoke, temporarily paralyzed, the sun was shining and the air was still. One of the other men was dead on his lap with a large burn streak running the length of his body. They called it "the bolt from the blue."

The odds of being struck by lightning are slim. There have been just five deaths due to lightning in the park's history.

TREES

Deaths from falling trees are relatively uncommon in the park, but they happen. In 1893, Ike Barrows and Patrick Sheahan were both killed by falling trees in separate incidents within the span of several months. Barrows had been doing government road work; Sheahan had been logging. Curiously, both men had testified in the first and second murder trials of Charles Northrup, a timber camp foreman who shot a disgruntled employee. Neither man was available for Northrup's third and final trial.

In 1966, Stephen Athan, who was camping with his wife and 3-year-old daughter, was fatally struck inside his tent by a falling lodgepole pine. The 300-year-old tree had a rust canker (a localized dead area on a tree branch or trunk caused by a rust fungus), which had rotted most of the tree. Athan's estate sued the government for wrongful death (and won), calling the lodgepole a "hazard tree." The case influenced the National Park Service's policies on trees in campgrounds. "Frustrated by these potential legal problems, the NPS in 1984 solved the problem at Bridge Bay by simply cutting down all of the trees in the campground," writes Whittlesey.

The probability of being killed by a falling tree in Yellowstone is low. In the history of the park, there have only been seven deaths due to falling trees.

AVALANCHES

Mountain lion researcher Gregory Felzien was tracking a large male mountain lion in Yellowstone's backcountry in February 1992. In a prescient moment, he'd told a friend, "If I ever have to die, I want it to be here in Yellowstone tracking cats." He was snowshoeing in the Lamar Valley, following the cat by radio transmitter, when an avalanche swept him away. Two nights before, his mother had dreamed he would be killed in an avalanche.

In another strange twist involving a scientist and an avalanche, geologist Diane Dustman had sent the 1st edition of *Death in Yellowstone* to a friend a year or so before her 1997 death in Yellowstone. She and geologist Rick Hutchinson had snowmobiled and skied into the park to study thermal features. The pair was caught in a massive avalanche on Factory Hill that buried Dustman under seven feet of snow. Sadly, her fate made it into the book's second edition.



Six people have died after being caught in avalanches in Yellowstone National Park.



A lodgepole pine in the fog at Pebble Creek in Yellowstone National Park. Photograph by Jim Peaco with U.S. National Park Service



FALLS

As of 2013, there had been at least 36 deaths from falls in Yellowstone. The storyline around falls repeats itself: A visitor backs up or climbs over a railing to get a better view or snap a photo, and then slips and falls. But the story of Earl and Louise Dunn has a different twist. In the summer of 1924, Earl was backing up their Ford coupe at Grand View, when he backed the car off the edge. It fell several hundred feet, bouncing off the Grand Canyon's rock walls. Ejected from the car, the couple landed 800 feet below the lip. "Mr. and Mrs. Dunn were mangled and broken and quite dead," Whittlesey writes.

In 1985, Kent Shane Rich made a solo ascent of 10,554-foot Thunderer Peak, known for its crumbly, andesitic talus. For reasons unknown, the 22-year-old plummeted some 600 feet from the summit. The day prior, Rich was riding through Hayden Valley with friends when the driver slammed on the brakes to avoid rear-ending a bison-watching tourist. "If I die out here, I want it to be from falling off a cliff, not from some car wreck," Rich said. By a stroke of fate, Rich's roommate and fellow Old Faithful Snow Lodge employee, John Mark Williams, died a few years later after stumbling into a 187° hot spring in a widely publicized case.

(top) Thunderer Peak, YNP, Wyoming. *Photograph by Mike Cline, public domain*

(bottom) Tourists view Yellowstone Falls from the Brink of the Lower Falls Trail. *Photograph courtesy of U.S. Geological Service*



As of 2013, there had been at least 36 deaths from falls in Yellowstone over the course of the park's history.



Since 1872, 125 people have died from drowning in the park, more than any other cause aside from car accidents and medical emergencies.

DROWNINGS

When *Death in Yellowstone* was published, Whittlesey reported there were more deaths by drowning than in any other category, car accidents and illness excepted. Yellowstone Lake, with its frigid temps, afternoon storms, and 450-foot depth, accounts for at least 40 deaths since the park was founded. The park's rivers have also proven deadly. In 1933, Christopher D. Gray, who was working in construction at Yellowstone Lake, illegally shot a Canada goose in the Hayden Valley. When he attempted to retrieve his quarry, he was swept downstream. Another poacher, George Palermo, drowned in 1982 while trying to illegally smuggle 250 pounds of elk antlers out of the park, transporting them by raft down the Gardner River.

In 1985, Mrs. Leroy Stuppy reported her husband, a science teacher and track coach from Pennsylvania, missing. Anglers often came home late, the rangers reassured her. But it was their anniversary, and she didn't think he would miss it. Suddenly, she noticed the sapphire in her wedding ring, meant to represent Leroy, had fallen out. She was sure something dire had happened. Indeed, Leroy's body was discovered several weeks later. He had drowned in the Yellowstone River.

Looking down from the lookout point at Brink of Lower Falls, over the Yellowstone River, as it flows eastward through the "Grand Canyon of Yellowstone".

Photograph courtesy of U.S. Geological Service

TO LOVE THE WILD IS TO RESPECT ITS EDGE

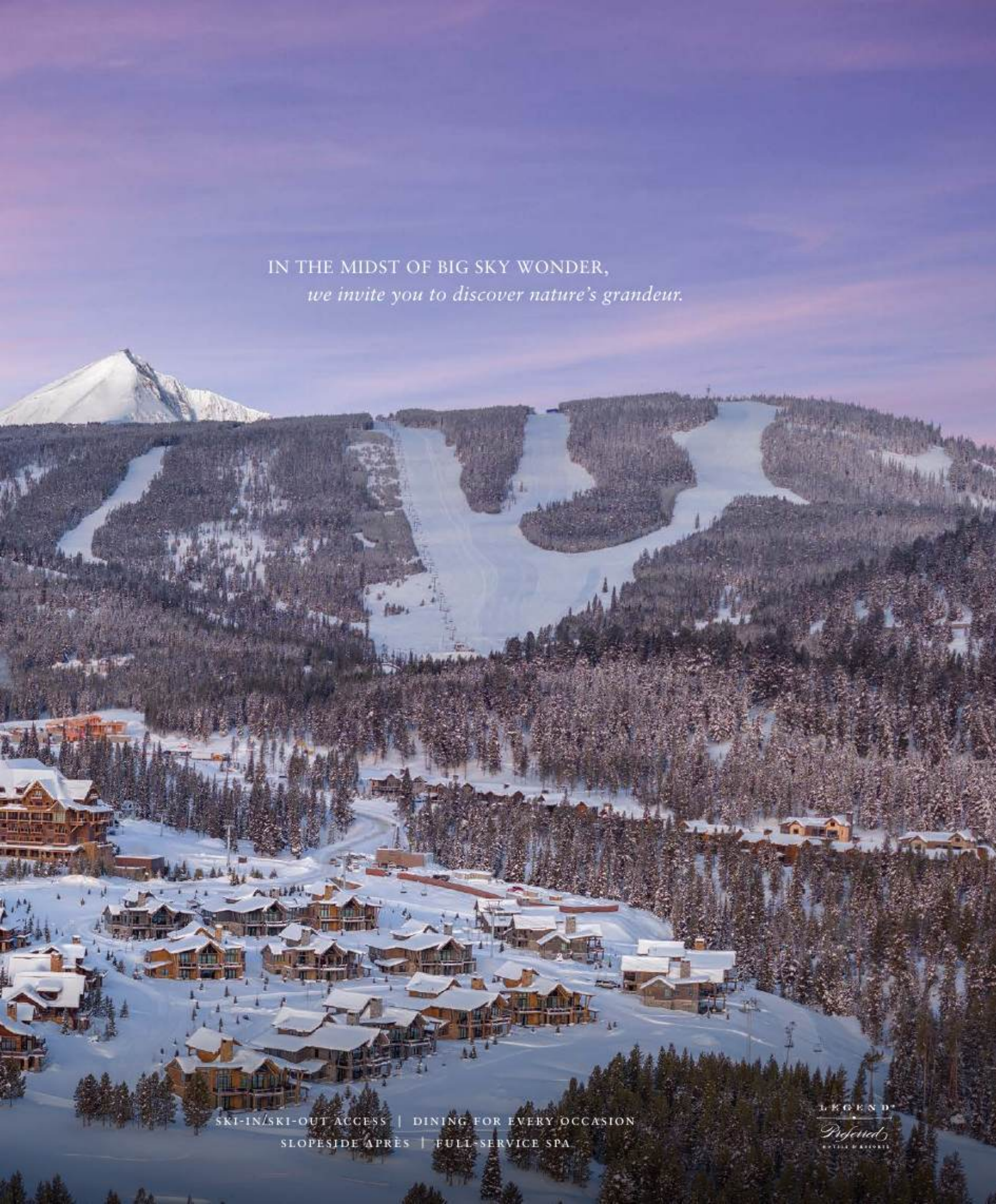
Most stories of death and misfortune have a common theme: foolhardiness. Park visitors get within 10 feet of a massive bison to capture a selfie. They leave the boardwalk, passing warning signs and crossing delicate mineral crust, to stare down the depths of a geyser or to urinate into it (yes, really). But it's not just the tourists who make the news. Kayaking guides, park rangers, wildlife biologists, and longtime employees are not immune. "It's not just people stumbling around with no experience," Murphy says. "Even experts need to be wary of Yellowstone's dangers."

People come to Yellowstone seeking a once-in-a-lifetime experience filled with joy and reverie, not tragedy. "It's very easy to Monday-morning quarterback people's decisions, especially on social media," Murphy says. "But anybody can get in over their heads. People need to have some compassion." We can't fault anyone for wanting to embrace raw nature: the ethereal beauty of mist rising above a shimmering hot pool, the thrill of spotting a grizzly with her cubs. Wild places like Yellowstone are dangerous, but therein lies the allure. What draws us to the park is the very same force that can lead to our undoing. And still, millions return each year, pulled by the same untamed beauty. Yellowstone asks only that we meet its majesty with open eyes—and with the humility that wild places command.



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An aerial photograph of a ski resort at dusk. The scene shows a large, snow-covered mountain with several ski runs. A dense forest of evergreen trees is scattered across the slopes. In the foreground, a cluster of rustic wooden buildings, likely lodges or chalets, are nestled in the snow. The sky is a mix of purple, pink, and blue, indicating the time is either dawn or dusk. The overall atmosphere is serene and majestic.

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Eating

Exploring Big Sky's Culinary Landscape



Photograph courtesy of The Waypoint

Local

Story by Carolyn Williams

When you live in a mountain town like Big Sky, your relationship with food isn't just about flavor—it's about community, atmosphere, and spots that feel like home. Here's a guide to locals' favorite spots, meals, and deals in Big Sky.

The Waypoint

Sitting right at the entrance to Town Center, the Waypoint feels like Big Sky's unofficial welcome sign. Part restaurant, part cinema, part community hub, it's known as the place for movie nights, Wednesday trivia, and casual meet-ups that make it feel like "where Big Sky comes together." The menu leans bistro-inspired with comforting mains, shareable plates, craft cocktails, and a full bar. Guests can dine upstairs, grab a table in the lounge, or carry their meal straight into the cinema for the full experience.

➔ **WHY LOCALS GO:** The Sunday night dinner-and-a-movie deal is a surefire way to beat the Sunday Scaries. Order any entrée and your movie ticket is on the house. Some folks eat before the film, others linger afterward, but the real pro move is bringing your plate into the theater and pairing it with a fresh tub of popcorn, made in-house with care.



A Big Sky staple: the \$7 fried chicken dinner at Riverhouse, known to sell out fast on busy nights. *Photograph by Joe Esenther*

The Riverhouse

Perched along the Gallatin River, The Riverhouse is Big Sky's backyard hangout. Known for its Texas-style barbecue—slow-smoked over mesquite and served with all the classic sides—it's the kind of place where work boots and wedding dresses coexist with ease.



WHY LOCALS GO: The setting is unmatched, whether you're catching up with neighbors or listening to live music under the Montana summer sky. In every season and after every activity—whether it be a day on the slopes, river, or trails—The Riverhouse is a go to for live music, a fantastic beer selection, and great company. The \$7 fried chicken dinner is a go-to, often paired with favorite sides like fried pickles or corn nuggets, but get there early: it usually sells out within an hour or two of opening.

The Saloon at Horn & Cattle

A true Western gathering spot, The Saloon at Horn & Cattle is where locals go to unwind with a cocktail after a day outside or at work (or both). The menu leans into hearty comfort food—think cedar plank mushrooms and a classic H&C Burger paired with a strong whiskey list or an unbeatable local brew.



The Saloon at Horn & Cattle, known for its warm atmosphere, strong cocktails, and classic comfort food.

Photograph courtesy of Saloon at Horn & Cattle



WHY LOCALS GO: For a Lone Peak (bourbon, rye, calvados, carpano antica, angostura bitters) and an H&C burger in a space that warms you up from the inside out. Many nights feature live music, but Tuesdays in the summer and winter are on another level thanks to the band Tuesday Night Rodeo Club. The trio blends Nashville polish with Montana grit and includes Montana's own Amanda Stewart, Nashville bassist/vocalist Annie Clements (Maren Morris, Sugarland), and guitarist/producer Thad Beaty (Grammy-nominated songwriter, Sugarland). Part honky-tonk, part jam session, all energy, the band's set list is never fixed. Call out a country classic, a rock anthem, or even a pop hit, and they'll run with it. No two nights are ever the same, which is what makes Tuesdays at the Saloon a can't-miss Big Sky tradition.



The Sacchetti al Tartufo at Michaelangelo's, a beloved house favorite filled with ricotta and black truffle in a rich tartufata cream sauce. *Photograph courtesy of Michaelangelo's*

Michaelangelo's

Tucked into Meadow Village, Michaelangelo's brings the flavors of Northern Italy to Big Sky. Run by brother-sister team Michael and Emily Annandono, the restaurant blends a welcoming atmosphere with Chef Michael's authentic training in Piedmont. The result is food that feels both elevated and heartfelt—a true Italian table set against the Montana mountains.



WHY LOCALS GO: It's the spot for a lingering dinner with friends, celebratory night out, or date night at their cozy bar. The house favorite is the Sacchetti al Tartufo: delicate pasta filled with ricotta and black truffle, finished in a rich tartufata cream sauce. Pair it with a glass of Italian red, and you'll see why locals keep coming back for more.

Blue Buddha Sushi Lounge

When locals crave sushi in the mountains, they head to Blue Buddha Sushi Lounge, Big Sky's go-to for fresh rolls and easy gatherings with friends. It's not unusual to come across a birthday celebration or a quiet date night unfolding over sake on the way to your table. For an even more laid-back vibe, grab a seat at the Drunken Monk, the bar just inside Blue Buddha, where the conversation flows as easily as the cocktails.

➔ **WHY LOCALS GO:** For the Beehive Roll, a nod to nearby Beehive Basin and a house favorite. It's a California roll topped with seafood and dynamite sauce, baked and served over lemon slices—equal parts comfort and creativity. Locals also love pulling up a seat at the Drunken Monk, a good spot for a late night scene complete with Japanese-inspired bar snacks like instant noodles and Asian Doritos as well as specialty cocktails like the Flaming Lotus—tequila, ginjo sake, lemon, serrano, mint and orange—made by Joe, local celebrity and resident Drunken Monk bartender.



Photograph by Joe Esenther

Blindside Burger

Blindside Burger is Big Sky's neon-splashed, family friendly spot known for its bold shakes and crispy smash burgers. It's quick, casual, and reliably good—the kind of place you stop after skiing, hiking, or running errands when you want something easy and satisfying.



WHY LOCALS GO: For the Shredder, the ultimate double smashburger layered with smoked gouda, caramelized onions, mushrooms, and their signature Blindside sauce. It's exactly what you want after a big day outside. Kids come for the Unicorn Toot Milkshake—a colorful, over-the-top creation that's as fun to look at as it is to drink. Dare them to finish it, but let's be honest, you'll definitely get at least a few sips; it's a shake fit to be shared.



Photograph by Joe Esenther



The Beef Pho from Big Sky Noodles, a warm and deeply satisfying bowl that hits the spot after a winter day or long hike.

Big Sky Noodles

For a town built for cold days and big appetites, Big Sky Noodles is pure comfort. The takeout-only noodle shop has become a local staple and is known for generous portions, fast service, and flavors that hit every craving. It's low-key and centrally located in Town Center, making it an easy walk if you live or are staying in the meadow (bring your dog!). It's exactly what you want when the temperature drops or you just don't feel like cooking.



WHY LOCALS GO: For the Beef Pho, a warm, savory bowl of broth, noodles, and thinly sliced beef that soothes everything from winter chill to post-hike hunger. It's simple, deeply satisfying, and always delicious. Afterward, make your way to their sister shop, Big Sky Scoops, for dessert. They serve up Montana's own Genuine Ice Cream, the perfectly sweet ending to a cozy night in.

Photograph by Green Door Photography

The Landing at One&Only Moonlight Basin

Tucked within Moonlight Basin, The Landing at One&Only is as stunning as it is welcoming. Floor-to-ceiling windows frame exceptional views of Lone Peak and Fan Mountain, drawing your eye across these alpenglow-laden peaks and the valleys that surround them. The interior is elevated yet comfortable—every texture and detail carefully curated. You can arrive by car or take the gondola from Big Sky's Madison Base when the mountain is open. Either way, the journey feels like part of the experience.



WHY LOCALS GO: For the views, the atmosphere, and the kindness with which you are greeted as soon as you arrive. The food is exceptional—refined yet unpretentious—and the setting makes lingering easy. The go-to order? The flagship half chicken schnitzel and a boot of beer (yes, a glass cowboy boot filled with a generous pour of your draft preference!); easygoing, delicious, and best enjoyed at the cozy bar or at a table overlooking the mountains with time to linger. Come for a meal, stay for the sunset, and don't be surprised when the friendly team celebrates you with the sound of the Landing's iconic train whistle when you order a boot!

The Landing's signature half chicken schnitzel, a refined yet easygoing favorite best paired with a boot of beer and a mountain view.



Photograph courtesy of Moonlight Basin



Directory

From quick bites to high-end mountain fare, bison ribeyes to gourmet hot dogs, mountain-high nachos to delectable sushi, Big Sky's dining variety offers something for everyone. *Scan the QR code to view a full directory of options.*



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A Montana Road Trip:

TIPPET RISE, RED LODGE, THE BEARTOOTH MOUNTAINS AND BEYOND

Story by Carolyn Williams

WHEN THE LONG LIGHT OF A MONTANA SUMMER stretches well past nine o'clock, it's hard not to feel the pull of the open road. Between late June and the end of September, the highways and backroads east of southwestern/central Montana are at their best. Green hills give way to rugged peaks that rise up from the plains. No matter what time of day you make the drive, the views are striking. This loop from Bozeman to Tippet Rise Art Center, then through Fishtail and Red Lodge before returning home over the Beartooth Pass and Yellowstone National Park, captures the very best of a Montana summer: art, mountains, good food, and wide-open sky.

Bozeman

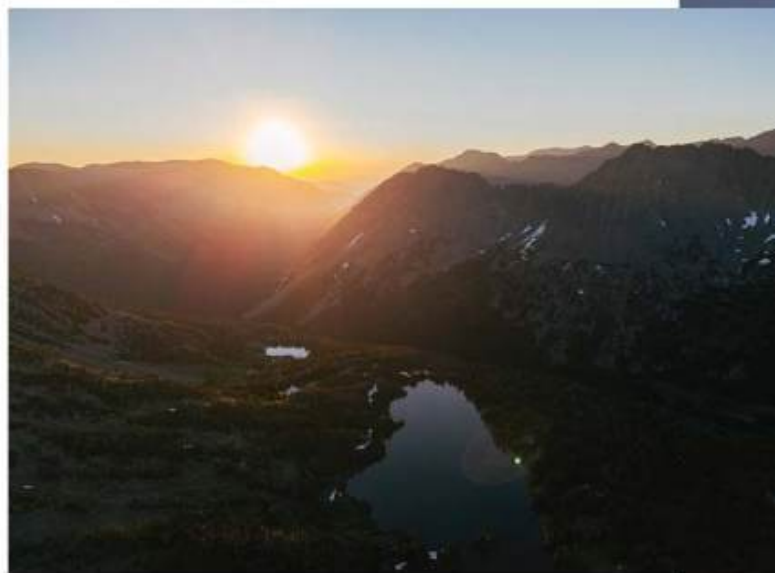


Morning coffee from Treeline Coffee Roasters, the perfect start before hitting the highway out of Bozeman. Photograph courtesy of Treeline Coffee Roasters

Start with a coffee in Bozeman (preferably early) before you hit the highway. Treeline Coffee Roasters on Wallace Avenue offers burritos and house-baked scones, while Roly-Poly on Broadway Avenue serves breakfast tacos made fresh to order. Just down the block from Treeline, Wild Crumb is famous for its croissants, tarts, and countless other pastries that are well worth the stop. If you'd rather get moving first, save your stop for the Gem in Livingston, just 26 miles east of Bozeman, a newer but beloved local spot that pairs excellent coffee with fresh pastries, breakfast sandwiches, and a warm welcome.

From Livingston, merge onto I-90 eastbound. To the south, the Absaroka Range stretches in jagged layers of stone. To the north, the Crazy Mountains rise sharp and solitary from the prairie. The drive alone is reason enough for the trip—open and uncluttered, with big-sky views that never get old.

The Crazy Mountains illuminated at sunrise. Photograph by Andy Austin



Take Exit 408 at Columbus, then follow signs toward Absarokee on Route 78. As you turn south, the Beartooth Mountains begin to dominate the horizon, their snowcapped plateaus gleaming even in midsummer.





TIPPET RISE ART CENTER

From Absarokee, turn right onto Garden Lane, which becomes Stillwater River Road. After six miles, turn left across from a white farmhouse onto Grove Creek Road and stay straight until you reach the Tippet Rise gate. You've arrived at Tippet Rise Art Center, one of Montana's most astonishing hidden art and cultural gems.



Beethoven's Quartet, 2003. Steel and stainless steel by Mark di Suvero.
Photograph by Erik Peterson

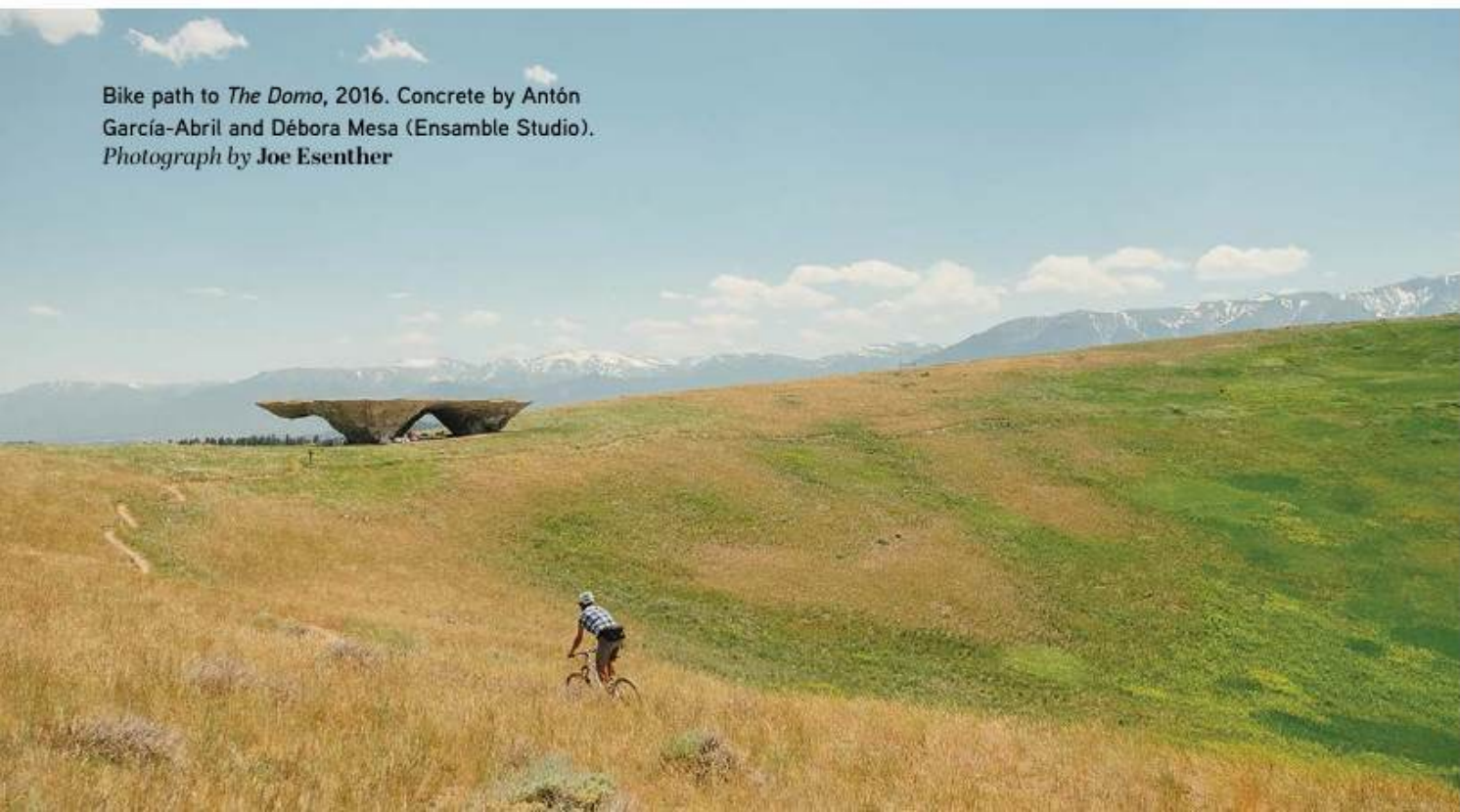
Before you go, know that reservations are required to visit. Entry is free, but tickets are released in early spring and often go quickly. Join their newsletter for updates, or check back the Wednesday before your intended visit since any returned tickets are re-released on the website. Concert tickets, usually \$10, also grant full-day access to the property's trails and sculptures.



The Beartooth Portal, 2015. Concrete, by Antón García-Abril and Débora Mesa (Ensamble Studio).
Photograph by Iwan Baan

Once inside, the world seems to open up in every direction. Tippet Rise spans 12,500 acres of working ranch land in the foothills of the Beartooths. The prairie itself feels like part of the collection, waves of grass rippling toward a horizon that ends where the Beartooth Range begins. Scattered across it are monumental sculptures by artists like Alexander Calder, Mark di Suvero, Ensamble Studio, Patrick Dougherty and Ai Weiwei, rising from the earth like beacons. You can hike, bike, or join a guided van tour to see them all. Avid mountain bikers will love the 15 miles of flow trails. Shade is scarce though, so come prepared with sun protection, snacks, and plenty of water. Most sculpture sites have water jugs available for refills.

Bike path to *The Domo*, 2016. Concrete by Antón García-Abril and Débora Mesa (Ensamble Studio).
Photograph by Joe Esenther





The Soil You See..., 2023. Glass and granite by Wendy Red Star. Photograph by James Florio

During the concert season, from mid-August through mid-September, PREROGATIVE Kitchen, a two-time James Beard semifinalist, serves lunch and dinner on Fridays and lunch on weekends. During the rest of the season, lunch service continues Fridays through Sundays. Their open-air café dishes up colorful salads, grain bowls, and light snacks, perfect for lingering before heading back out on the trail. You're welcome to bring your own picnic too; there's nothing quite like eating lunch with the Beartooths stretched across your viewscape.

Keep in mind that Tippet Rise is a working ranch, so you may encounter sheep, cattle, or the occasional herding dog. The landscape is alive, and weather can change quickly. That wildness is part of the experience.

Archway II, 1984. Red-painted steel by Wendy Red Star. Photograph by James Florio



Interior view of the Olivier Music Barn at Tippet Rise. Photograph by Kevin Kinzley



When you've had your Tippet Rise fill, head toward Fishtail, a small community at the base of the Beartooths that embodies small-town Montana. The Fishtail General Store is worth a stop. Established in 1900, it's stocked with everything from homemade pies to burritos, popcorn, and produce. It's also the kind of place where you'll find neighbors catching up by the door and visitors lingering longer than planned.



Downtown Red Lodge in summertime, where every corner hums with mountain-town spirit. *Photograph by Andy Austin*

FROM THERE, continue down the road to Red Lodge, a vibrant mountain town tucked at the base of the Beartooths. The drive between Fishtail and Red Lodge is one of the most scenic in the state. Rolling ranch land gives way to mountain peaks that seem to draw closer with every mile. Drive slowly and with care, especially as dusk approaches. Wildlife crosses the road frequently.

78



Italian dishes from Ox Pasture by Piccolo Cucina, where refined mountain dining meets the easy warmth of Red Lodge. *Photograph by Allison Kazmierski (Font & Figure)*

Once in Red Lodge, settle in for the night. The Yodeler Motel is a local favorite with a retro feel and sauna-style bathrooms, while the Pollard Hotel offers historic charm right downtown. There are plenty of Airbnb and VRBO options for families or travelers with dogs. Book well in advance—Red Lodge is busy all summer long.

Dinner in Red Lodge can be as casual or refined as you like. Try One Legged Magpie for excellent modern comfort food, Ox Pasture by Piccolo Cucina for elevated yet relaxed mountain Italian dining, or Bogart's for laid-back burgers, pizza and margaritas. Afterward, stop by Red Lodge Pizza Co. for a scoop of Montana-made Wilcoxson's ice cream and wander into the Candy Emporium, where classic sweets and treats line every shelf and table.

The next morning, head to Cattail Bakery, where the line moves fast and the pastries are flaky, buttery, and baked fresh daily. Across the street, stop by Hidden Basin Coffee, a newer café that evolved from a beloved food truck. Locally owned and led with heart, it's the kind of place that makes you want to linger over a second cup. Their smoothies are perfect if you're craving something light before a day on the road.



One Legged Magpie mixes cocktails as intentionally as it cultivates its warm, inviting space. *Photograph courtesy of One Legged Magpie*



A mother mountain goat and her kid on the Beartooth Pass, thriving in the rugged alpine terrain that defines this iconic stretch of the Rockies. *Photograph by Andy Austin*



The Beartooth Highway, one of America's most spectacular alpine drives. *Photograph by Andy Austin*

From downtown, continue south on Main Street, which turns seamlessly into the Beartooth Scenic Highway, one of the most breathtaking drives in the world. As you climb, mountainscapes surround you on all sides, replete with mountain goats balancing on rocky ledges. Even in midsummer, snowbanks linger near the summit and the air feels clear and clean. Take your time. This is a drive to savor.

From the top, you can loop back to Bozeman through Red Lodge or continue over the pass toward Cooke City and Silver Gate, entering the northeast corner of Yellowstone National Park. This is the park's wildest and least-traveled entrance, where bison often graze along the road and the Lamar Valley opens wide with sweeping views and abundant wildlife. It's not uncommon to spot pronghorn, elk, or even a grizzly in the distance. Continue west through Tower Junction and Mammoth Hot Springs, then out through Gardiner for an easy return to Paradise Valley and home. Or head south through Canyon Village toward West Yellowstone, where the road traces the rim of the Grand Canyon of the Yellowstone before crossing forests and meadows on the way to the park's western edge. Either route offers a fitting finale to the trip—a reminder of just how vast and varied this corner of Montana and Wyoming really is.

However you choose to head home, the route leaves an imprint. Tippet Rise, with its fusion of art, music, and landscape, feels like a secret whispered across the prairie, a reminder of how creativity and wildness coexist here in the heart of Montana. The drive itself, stitched together with small towns, winding roads, and high mountain passes, is its own masterpiece. In summer, with the light long and the roads clear, there is no better way to experience the quiet grandeur of this corner of the world.

Elk roaming the meadows of Lamar Valley. *Photograph by Kerry Hargrove*



Best traveled from late June through September. Reservations for Tippet Rise open in early spring and are required for all visits. Visit tippetrise.org to learn more.



SURROUNDED BY MOUNTAINS,

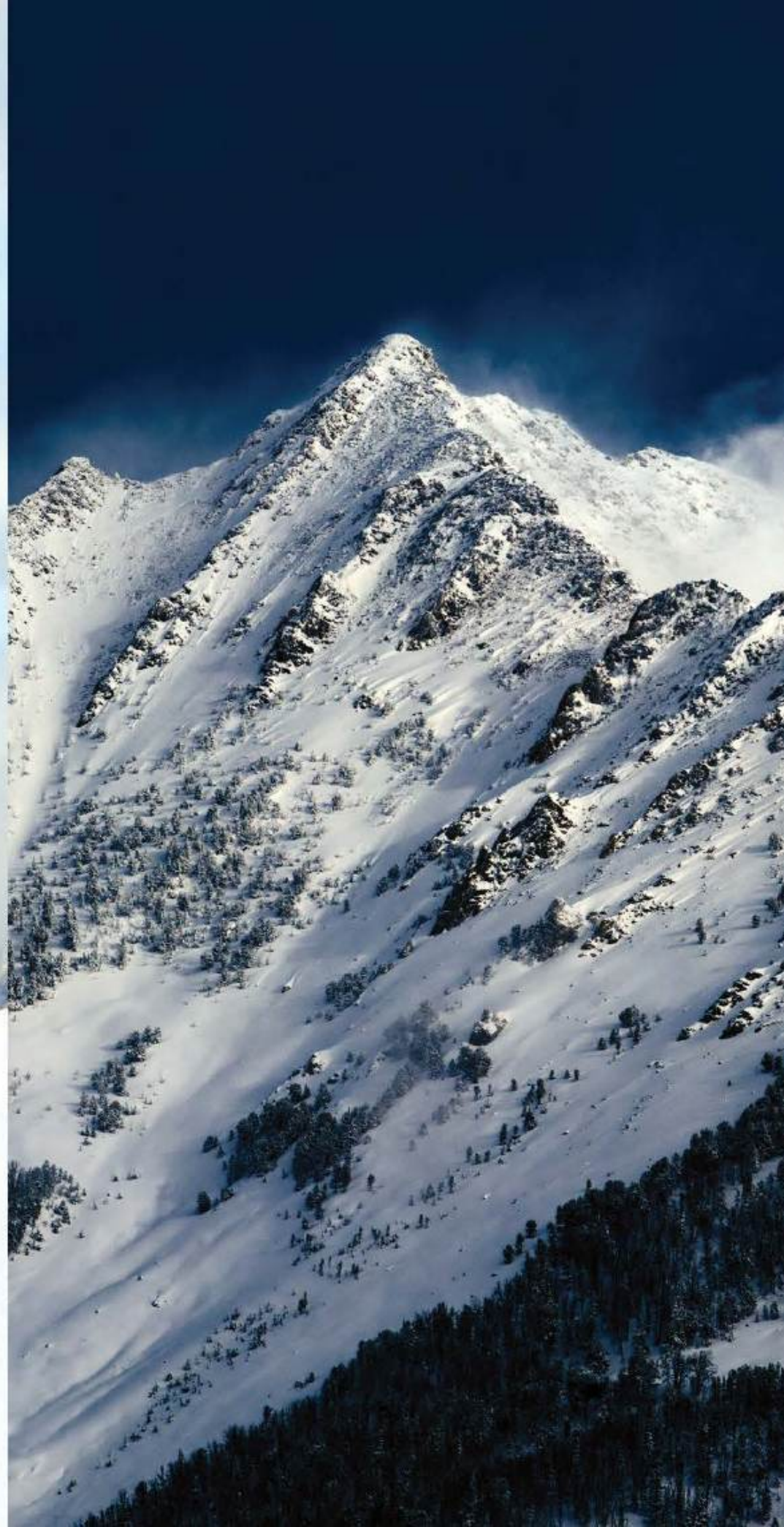
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SIX LOCALS. SIX DAYS. ONE BIG SKY.

Story by Megan Michelson

**Unfiltered
narratives from
the heart of
the community.
Discover what it's
really like to call
Big Sky home.**

BIG SKY RESIDENTS KNOW HOW TO MAKE THE MOST OF A DAY, though no two days ever look the same. From pre-dawn yoga to late-night music, life here shifts with the seasons, the weather, and the moment. We talked to locals ranging in age from 7 to 72 to hear what an ideal Big Sky day might look like for them. Their stories are as varied as the landscape itself, yet all share a deep appreciation for the place they call home.



Bridget and a friend with their dogs on the Spanish Peaks Nordic trails. *Photography courtesy of Bridget Henrichon*

BRIDGET HENRICHON

Wellness Director

Tram laps, Nordic trails with the dog, and an epic backyard rope tow

Born and raised in Big Sky, Bridget Henrichon (née French) left her hometown for college and a career in the hospitality industry, but in 2019, she returned to Big Sky, where the 33-year-old currently works as director of wellness and membership at Moonlight Basin. When she's not working, this is how she spends her ideal winter day.



Backyard hangs at the Henrichons' home provide the perfect ending to an idyllic Big Sky winter day.

7 AM

Check the snow report while making breakfast. Boot up for skiing at home, then load everything in the truck: skis, dog, Nordic skis. I'm not sure what the day will entail, so I'll bring it all.

9 AM

I park on the Spanish Peaks side of the mountain, then ride Lewis and Clark to Southern Comfort, then straight to the tram. I'll head to Dictator Chutes or Lenin and Marx if there's powder. Otherwise, I'll go back to Andesite Mountain to ski some groomers.

1:30 PM

The tonkotsu ramen at Backcast at the Montage is so good. I like a late lunch to take advantage of all the good skiing in the morning.

3 PM

I'll head to the truck and switch to my Nordic ski gear. The Spanish Peaks Nordic trails are dog friendly, so I'll take my dog out for an hour of skate skiing.

5 PM

We have a 500-vertical-foot hill in our backyard, so we got a tiny rope tow, made in Vermont, that's hooked up to our electricity. We invite our friends and neighbors over and we pow surf or sled. The kids build jumps and ski. We cook sausages over the fire and everyone brings a dish to share. I'm in my ski clothes until at least 8 p.m. We end the day with s'mores around the fire.



NIKO GIANNIOSES

Wildland Firefighter

From fire lines to fishing lines: a summer day in Big Sky

Ski and bike patroller Niko Giannioses, 30, works as a wildland firefighter for the Big Sky Fire Department in the summers, which means long days in the field, followed by evenings of hanging with his dogs, fishing, and running local trails.



When Niko's not working as a wildland firefighter, he's out exploring Big Sky's trails on foot or by bike, usually with at least one pup in tow. *Photography courtesy of Niko Giannioses*

6:40 AM After I let my dogs out and make coffee, I bike to work on the bike path—it's only about 10 minutes by bike from my house to the fire department.

7 AM We'll have a morning briefing about our plan for the day, where we'll be working, and what the weather is doing. Then we gear up and head out the door to our job site, usually driving a brush truck and two utility vehicles. At the job site, we'll spend all day clearing fuels on the ground, limbing trees, increasing canopy space, all the while keeping in mind the species diversity in the forest and working to make the forest healthier.



Endless miles of dog-friendly trails mean the lives of Big Sky pups like Niko's are the stuff of canine dreams.



4 PM It's back to the shop to clean up our gear and make sure everything's ready for the next day. I'll bike home and take my dogs out and then if it's nice out, I'll go fishing on the Gallatin River. I've got easy access to fishing just five or 10 minutes from my house. Some nights, my girlfriend and I will go for a trail run after work.

6:30 PM If it's a Wednesday, I'll head to the Big Sky farmers' market, where you can see a lot of locals and check out different artisans and vendors. I might wait in line for a loaf of bread from Sinclair's Bakery or grab a bison burger for dinner from the Rancho Picante food truck.

8 PM I'll meet friends for a beer at Beehive Basin Brewery. I like the Green Bridge IPA, it's a classic.

TOVA TRAXLER

Second Grader

Ski school, gummy worms, and snowball fights with Buckets

A student at Ophir Elementary, 7-year-old Tova Traxler spends her Saturdays in the winter playing outside with friends and racing down the mountain on skis.

7 AM Breakfast is eggs or an açai bowl, then I get my ski gear on: snow pants, boots, gloves. I grab my helmet, goggles, and skis and poles. I always pack candy in my pockets and face glitter, which I share with my ski group.

9:45 AM I meet my ski group and my coach, whose name is Greg, but he tells us to call him Buckets. Once, he wore an actual bucket on his head.

10 AM We'll ride Ramcharger or Swifty to Powderseeker. We might stop for a break at the Snack Shack, where they sometimes give us gummy worms.

12:15 PM My parents usually pack me a lunch and all the ski lesson groups eat together in the Huntley Lodge. After lunch, we play on this snowy hill where you can throw snowballs at your coach. Once, Buckets fell while skiing, so we all got to throw snowballs at him.



With pockets full of candy and glitter, Tova's ready to hit the slopes.



1 PM There are these super fun runs called Banana Land, Harbor's Halfpipe, and the terrain park. You get to ski through these tubes and one of them has a sign with a bear on it. Some of these runs will get you a sticker you can put on your helmet.

3:15 PM After skiing, I'll go home and play in the snow some more, like sledding in the meadow or burying myself in the snow. Then I might take a hot tub.

6 PM If I'm lucky, we'll go ice skating in Town Center. Then, we'll get pizza from Pinky G's before going home for a popcorn movie night with my dogs.

Both on and off the mountain, Tova's an adventurer at heart.
Photography courtesy of Krista Traxler



KAREN MENDOZA

Community Advocate

Building community and confidence on the mountain

A native of Texas, Karen Mendoza moved to Big Sky four years ago having barely seen snow. She learned how to ski, thanks to a scholarship from Women of Winter, and got her Level I certification to work as a ski instructor. Now, Mendoza, 31, is the cofounder of *Recreamos Juntos*, a Big Sky-based nonprofit she started with Isaac Galindo that works to introduce the local Latino population to outdoor recreation in the area.



6 AM I work out at the Big Sky Community Center, taking a spin class or bootcamp class at BASE. It's the only way I know how to start my day.

9 AM After a quick shower and breakfast, I'm out the door to head up to the mountain. We teach bilingual Spanish and English ski lessons for everyone from first timers on skis to those who've come back for repeated lessons throughout the winter. Usually, our day starts on the Explorer lift. We work with Big Sky Resort and other community partners to provide this opportunity to the local Latino population with things like discounted tickets, gear rental, and free instruction. That's the cool thing about this community: If you notice a hole in the community, or a group of people whose needs aren't being met, we say, let's do this together. We can figure this out.

1 PM We'll stop for lunch at Vista Hall. I always give everyone the option of calling it quits after lunch or continuing to ski and almost everyone wants to stay out there.

5 PM If everyone's still up for hanging out, we'll gather at Riverhouse for some barbecue. People are usually so stoked and worn out from the day, they just want to relive those memories. They have so much pride in themselves for doing something new and finding a group they can join. It's the same way I felt when I learned to ski and it's a gift to be able to pass that feeling on.

8 PM After dinner, I'll head home and regroup. I try to read 50 pages a day and I journal to clear my mind. I'll write down things I need to get done or where I'm at on a scale of one to 10 in energy, compassion, and passion. I always write down 10 things I'm grateful for. That's easy to come up with living here. I'm a kid who failed at P.E. and never saw snow, and now I'm running up mountains and teaching people to ski. Who would have thought?



Karen and friends enjoy a snowy moment at the top of Swift Current. For Karen, skiing means community building and empowering those around her. *Photography courtesy of Karen Mendoza*



KATE WILLIAMS

Pickleball Enthusiast

Yoga, pickleball, and spreading gratitude around town

Whatever you do, don't call Kate Williams retired. The 72-year-old Big Sky resident is as busy as she's ever been.

7:30 AM Santosha, which means a state of wellbeing, is a wonderful independently owned local yoga studio that has yoga and pilates, sound bathing, and massage. My morning yoga class at Santosha strengthens and balances me. I set an intention for my day, which is usually that I'm so full of gratitude to be able to live the way I live. I want to take that gratitude and spread it everywhere, give it out. I want to spray paint the town with gratitude.

8 AM If you stop for coffee at the Hungry Moose, you'll see everyone in town.

9 AM Pickleball at the community park is a big deal. I play for two to three hours most mornings. Big Sky Community Organization recently refurbished the courts and they're beautiful, with indoor and outdoor options. Pickleball is the most democratic sport I know: You don't have to have a partner, you just show up. If you don't have a paddle or ball, we have extras. If you don't know how to play, we teach you. The more players we have, the more happiness there is.

Kate with Lone Peak in the distance, carrying the same spirit she brings to pickleball: show up, welcome everyone, and spread joy wherever you go.

Photography courtesy of The Williams family



2 PM I teach mahjong at the community center or my house to anyone who wants to learn to play. Or I'll go shelve books at the library at the Ophir School or help neighbors wash windows. It's nice to be able to pay it forward in this community that's given me so much.

4 PM I love riding my bike almost more than playing pickleball. I'll ride my gravel bike around the streets of my neighborhood to see everyone's gardens and say hello to neighbors and friends who are out walking their dogs or playing with their children.

6:10 PM My husband, Ted, and I will order a flatbread pizza and a beet salad at the Rocks. It's quiet there, but you can still connect with people if you'd like. All of Big Sky feels like the bar in Cheers. Everyone knows your name. We know each other, we interact, we see how everyone is doing.

Kate after claiming victory in a Big Sky pickleball tournament, cooling down with a La Croix and taking in the moment.





Powder turns for Dave Stergar, a retired teacher who now spends much of winter immersed in the steep, snow-filled lines he's skied for decades. *Photograph by Rob Koehn*



Photograph by Christy Stergar



DAVE STERGAR

Retired Schoolteacher

A winter Saturday built around snow, friends, and après

Dave Stergar spent 27 years as a middle school science teacher in Helena, but over those years, he was always drawn to Big Sky for its steep skiing and community feel. These days, the 58-year-old former mountain ambassador and Big Sky guide skis 125 days a winter.

6:45 AM I'll open the windows and look outside to see what the weather did overnight. Depending on conditions, I'll either hustle making breakfast or I'll take my time.

8:15 AM It's a seven-minute walk from my condo to the mountain. I get booted up at my locker. Then, depending on if it snowed or not, I'll go wait in the line at Swift Current or ski groomers off Andesite Mountain.

10 AM I'm a tram rat, so eventually, I'll make my way up to the tram. There's so much good skiing at Big Sky, but you cannot beat the 2,200 vertical feet off the top of Lone Mountain back to the tram. I like how the Dictator Chutes or Lenin and Marx hold snow and get smoothed out. There's always good skiing somewhere.

3 PM I don't stop for lunch—I just grab a bar from my pocket to keep me going—so by midafternoon, I'm ready to call it quits. I'll head to Scissorbills for après and get tots or pretzel sticks. Meeting up with friends, talking about your day—that's one of the most fun parts about skiing.

9 PM Usually, I'm getting ready for bed, but if there's a band playing at Tips Up, I'll head into town to listen to music. There's always something to do at night in Big Sky if that's what you're after.

FROM TRAM LAPS AND CANDY-FILLED POCKETS to bilingual ski lessons, pickleball community, backyard bonfires, and dog-friendly trail adventures, no two days in Big Sky are completely alike. But while the details differ, the spirit is the same. These moments reveal a Big Sky community made stronger by people who lift each other up and find joy in the mountains that shape their days.

F.A.T. ICE RACE

2026

**ZELL AM SEE, AT
JAN 31, 2026**

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2026

**BIG SKY, MT
FEB 27-28, 2026**

Montana

Big Sky



2026

**BIG SKY,
MONTANA, US**

ICE

FAT ICE RACE IS

BACK IN THE US

RACE



F.A.T. ICE RACE

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2026

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The Spanish Peaks, moody and magnificent, rising through winter shadow and light.

Photograph by Joe Esenther

